

MOTOS AMERICA UNIVERSITY

MANAGEMENT ACADEMY

Professional Management Training Manual

Live the Passion. Take the Ride.

Department Managers • General Managers

PART I

LEADING THE DEPARTMENT

The frontline responsibilities of a Motos America manager: mindset, culture, people, and the operating fundamentals that keep a department running well.

MODULE 01

Welcome to Management Academy

You were promoted because you were excellent at a job. You will succeed as a manager only if you're willing to stop doing that job and start building people who can.

Every other manual in this university teaches someone how to be excellent in a single seat — behind the counter, on the sales floor, at the service desk, in the shop. This manual teaches something different. It teaches you how to be excellent through other people, in a seat where your own hands rarely touch the customer directly anymore, and where your results are almost entirely the sum of decisions other people make when you're not standing next to them.

That's a harder job than the one you came from. It is also a more important one.

PART 1

WHY THIS MANUAL EXISTS

Every academy at Motos America — Sales, Service, Technician, Parts & Accessories, F&I, Passport — teaches a frontline discipline. Management Academy assumes you've already completed the academy for your department, or that you're deeply familiar with its content. This manual doesn't re-teach how to sell a motorcycle, write a repair order, or build an accessory package. It teaches what changes once your job is no longer to do those things yourself, but to make sure a team of people does them consistently, well, and in a way that reflects the Motos America standard.

This manual is built for every department manager, regardless of discipline:

- ▶ Sales Managers
- ▶ Service Managers
- ▶ Parts Managers
- ▶ F&I Managers

You'll notice something as you move through this manual: a meaningful portion of it isn't specific to any one department at all. Coaching a struggling employee, running a fair performance conversation, reading a dashboard, managing a schedule, resolving conflict between two team members — these skills look almost identical whether you manage the sales floor or the parts counter. Motos America deliberately trains all department managers together, in one manual, because a manager who only understands their own department is a manager who can't step in, cover, or think dealership-wide when it matters. Modules 12 through 15 will walk you through the fundamentals of every other department specifically so you can speak intelligently about work you don't personally perform — not to make you an expert in someone else's craft, but so you're never the manager standing in a cross-department conversation with nothing useful to contribute.

EVERY DEPARTMENT MANAGER AT MOTOS AMERICA SPEAKS ONE COMMON LANGUAGE OF LEADERSHIP, LAYERED ON TOP OF THEIR OWN DEPARTMENT'S CRAFT

PART 2

THE SHIFT NOBODY WARNS YOU ABOUT

Ask a brand-new manager what changed the day they got promoted, and most describe a title, an office, a new set of meetings. Ask them again six months in, and the honest ones describe something much harder to put into words: a complete change in what "doing a good job" even means.

As an individual contributor, your job had a clear, personal scoreboard. You sold the bike. You wrote the ticket. You closed the sale, filled the order, protected the deal. Success was something you did.

As a manager, success is something you produce through other people — often people who are having a worse day than you, who disagree with your approach, who are learning a skill you mastered years ago and find frustrating along the way. Your best day as an individual contributor might have been the day you personally out-performed everyone around you. Your best day as a manager is the day someone on your team out-performs you, and it happened because you built them to.

- ▶ As an individual contributor, being the best in the room made you valuable
- ▶ As a manager, making everyone else in the room better is what makes you valuable
- ▶ The instinct to jump in and just do it yourself — because it's faster, because you're better at it, because you can see exactly what's wrong — is the single hardest habit to unlearn, and the one that quietly caps how far a department can grow

This isn't a small adjustment. It's a genuine identity shift, and it takes most new managers longer than they expect to fully make it. Give yourself permission to feel clumsy at this for a while. You are not failing at management because delegating feels less satisfying than doing; you're simply early in a transition every manager in this building has gone through.

YOUR JOB CHANGED FROM BEING GREAT AT THE WORK TO BEING GREAT AT THE PEOPLE WHO DO THE WORK

PART 3

THE THREE THINGS THIS MANUAL WILL BUILD IN YOU

This manual — and Management Academy as a whole — is organized around three things every effective Motos America manager needs, each covered in real depth rather than as a checklist:

- ▶ *People leadership.* Hiring the right person, coaching in the moment, having the performance conversation nobody enjoys, and building a team that trusts you enough to tell you the truth.
- ▶ *Operational management.* Reading your numbers accurately, building a schedule that serves both the business and the humans on it, and understanding the budget and P&L levers that are actually inside your control.
- ▶ *Culture and standard.* Carrying the "Live the Passion. Take the Ride." standard as something you personally model, not just something you enforce — including your department's role in the Passport experience, which you're not simply expected to know but personally responsible for keeping alive on your team.

Part I of this manual, which you're beginning now, covers the frontline reality of running a department day to day. Part II moves into the advanced layer: the General Manager relationship, structured goal-setting, building genuinely high-performing teams, and the judgment calls that separate a manager who keeps the department running from one who makes it exceptional. Part II closes with the Apex Manager capstone, which ties every prior module into a single day-in-the-life system you can actually run.

PART 4

THE STATE RITUAL, NOW AS A LEADERSHIP TOOL

You already know the State Ritual from your department academy — Breath Up, Posture Up, Focus Up with your North Star, Smile and Move. As an individual contributor, you used it to walk onto the floor, into the shop, or behind the counter ready to serve a customer well.

As a manager, the State Ritual has a second job. The state you walk into a one-on-one, a Monday morning huddle, or a tense conversation in is the single biggest variable in how that interaction goes — bigger, most days, than anything you actually say. A team can absorb a manager who's having a hard

quarter. A team struggles to absorb a manager who's having a hard *moment* and lets it leak into every interaction that follows. Module 05 goes deep on managing your own state under real pressure. For now, simply notice this: everything you do in this manual sits on top of the same four steps you already know. Nothing new to learn — just a new reason to take them seriously.

A LEADER'S BAD DAY BECOMES THE WHOLE TEAM'S BAD DAY UNLESS THE LEADER MANAGES THEIR OWN STATE FIRST

PART 5

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE IN THIS ROLE

By the end of this manual, you'll be equipped to:

- ▶ Lead people through coaching and accountability rather than through control or avoidance
- ▶ Read your department's numbers with real fluency, and use them to make decisions rather than just report them upward
- ▶ Speak intelligently across every department at Motos America, not just your own
- ▶ Carry the Passport standard as a manager — actively coaching your team on their handoffs, not simply assuming it happens
- ▶ Understand your relationship to your General Manager, and your GM's relationship to the whole dealership
- ▶ Build a team that performs well because they trust you, not because they fear you

THIS MANUAL DOESN'T TEACH YOU TO MANAGE A DEPARTMENT. IT TEACHES YOU TO BUILD ONE

GOAL OF MODULE 1

Every manager understands that Management Academy assumes department-level mastery already in place, and instead builds the shared leadership layer on top of it — people leadership, operational management, and culture — that applies no matter which department they run.

MODULE 2 — From Team Member to Team Leader

MODULE 01 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to this module, what does Management Academy assume about the reader before they begin?

- A. That they have already completed Executive Academy**
- B. That they have managed people at a previous company**
- C. That they have already completed, or are deeply familiar with, their own department's academy**
- D. That they have no prior experience in any department**

2. Why does this module say all department managers are trained together in one manual, rather than in separate manuals per department?

- A. Most of the core leadership skills look nearly identical across departments, and a manager who only understands their own department can't think dealership-wide**
- B. It's faster to produce one manual than four**
- C. Department managers are expected to rotate through every department**
- D. Corporate requires all managers to be cross-certified**

3. According to Part 2, what is the "hardest habit to unlearn" when moving from individual contributor to manager?

- A. Learning to use the scheduling software**
- B. Delegating too much, too soon**
- C. Attending more meetings**
- D. The instinct to jump in and do the work yourself instead of building the team to do it**

4. What is the "second job" of the State Ritual once someone becomes a manager?

- A. The state a manager brings into an interaction shapes that interaction more than what they actually say**
- B. It's used only during customer-facing moments, never internal ones**
- C. It becomes optional once a person reaches management**
- D. It replaces the need for a Knowledge Check**

5. According to this module, what is a manager's specific responsibility regarding the Passport process?

- A. Passport responsibility only applies to the General Manager**
- B. Managers are only responsible for Passport during the sales transaction**
- C. Passport is handled entirely by Passport Academy and doesn't require manager involvement**
- D. Managers are personally responsible for actively coaching their team's handoffs, not simply assuming Passport happens**

MODULE 02

From Team Member to Team Leader

Your title changed the day you were promoted. Your authority didn't — not really — until the people you lead decided to give it to you.

A promotion comes with a new title, sometimes a new office or a new badge, and a start date. What it doesn't come with is instant credibility. The people who now report to you watched you before you were their manager — some of them worked beside you, some trained you, some competed with you for the very role you now hold. Whatever trust and respect you build from here forward, you build the same way anyone does: by how you actually lead, day after day, not by what your title says you're allowed to do.

PART 1

THE GAP BETWEEN AUTHORITY AND RESPECT

Authority is granted. Respect is earned. Motos America gives every new manager the authority that comes with the role on day one — the ability to set schedules, make decisions, hold people accountable. Nobody can give you the second thing. Respect has to be built, and it's built through a hundred small moments rather than one announcement.

- ▶ Authority gets people to comply. Respect gets people to actually follow you when you're not in the room
- ▶ New managers who lead only on authority often get short-term compliance and long-term resentment
- ▶ New managers who wait to lead until they feel they've "earned it" often lead too passively and let real problems slide

The answer isn't choosing one over the other — it's using the authority you already have to create the conditions where respect can be earned quickly: clear expectations, consistent follow-through, and treating people fairly even when it's inconvenient.

YOUR TITLE GIVES YOU THE RIGHT TO LEAD. YOUR BEHAVIOR DECIDES WHETHER PEOPLE ACTUALLY LET YOU

PART 2

MANAGING PEOPLE WHO USED TO BE YOUR PEERS

For many new managers, the hardest version of this transition is leading people who were recently your equals — people you used to vent to about management decisions, people you're now expected to hold accountable to those same decisions. This is one of the most common places new managers stumble, usually in one of two directions: either they overcorrect and become distant or overly formal to "prove" they're serious, or they underreact and keep operating like a peer, avoiding the hard conversations a manager has to have.

WEAK: *"I know this is awkward since we used to be on the same level, so... just try to hit your numbers, okay? No pressure."*

STRONG: *"I want to be straight with you — things are a little different now that I'm in this seat, and that might feel strange for both of us for a bit. What hasn't changed is that I've got your back and I want you to succeed here. What has changed is that it's now my job to make sure the whole team, including you, is hitting the standard. I'd rather be upfront about that than pretend it's not true."*

The strong version does three things the weak version doesn't: it names the awkwardness instead of pretending it isn't there, it reaffirms the relationship, and it's honest about what the new role actually requires. Most former peers respect directness here far more than they respect being managed around.

- ▶ Have this conversation early, ideally in the first week, rather than letting it go unspoken
- ▶ Expect it to feel uncomfortable the first few times you hold a former peer accountable — discomfort doesn't mean you're doing it wrong
- ▶ Watch for the trap of managing one former peer more gently than the rest of the team out of guilt; uneven standards erode trust faster than almost anything else a manager does

PART 3

LETTING GO OF BEING THE BEST IN THE ROOM

Every manager in this manual was promoted, at least in part, because they were excellent at the job itself. That excellence is exactly what makes delegation so hard — you can see the faster way, the better way, the way you'd do it yourself, and every fiber of instinct says to just take over.

Resist it. Every time you take back a task because you can do it faster, you save five minutes today and cost your team a skill they never get to build. Multiply that across a year, and the manager who "helps" the most is often the one who has quietly built the least capable team.

- ▶ If you find yourself constantly stepping in, ask whether the real problem is the employee's skill — or your own tolerance for watching someone learn
- ▶ A team member who is allowed to struggle through a problem under your guidance grows. A team member who is rescued every time doesn't
- ▶ The goal isn't to disappear and offer no help. It's to become the person who asks the right question instead of the person who supplies the right answer

A MANAGER WHO NEVER LETS ANYONE STRUGGLE IS QUIETLY BUILDING A TEAM THAT CAN'T FUNCTION WITHOUT THEM

PART 4

YOUR FIRST NINETY DAYS

New managers who are deliberate about their first ninety days build credibility far faster than those who simply react to whatever comes up. A simple structure:

- ▶ *Days 1–30: Listen and learn.* Meet individually with every person on your team. Ask what's working, what's frustrating, and what they wish someone would fix. Resist making major changes yet — you're building the map before you redraw it.
- ▶ *Days 31–60: Establish rhythm.* Put your one-on-ones, huddles, and reporting habits in place. Start making the small fixes that don't require major buy-in — the ones people have been silently waiting for someone to address.
- ▶ *Days 61–90: Set direction.* With real understanding of your team and department now in hand, begin setting goals and expectations that are genuinely yours, not just inherited from your predecessor.

Skipping the listening phase is the single most common mistake new managers make. Arriving with a list of changes before understanding why things are the way they are reads as arrogance, even when the changes themselves are correct.

PART 5

WHO YOU LEAN ON WHILE YOU LEARN

No manager figures this out alone, and Motos America doesn't expect you to. Your General Manager is your first resource — not just for escalations, but for the ordinary, "is this normal?" questions every new manager has. The managers of other departments are a second resource; a Service Manager who's three years into the role has usually already made — and survived — the mistake you're about to make. Use them.

- ▶ Ask questions early rather than waiting until a small problem becomes a big one
- ▶ Treat other department managers as colleagues to learn from, not competitors to outperform
- ▶ The manager who asks for help in the first ninety days looks far better a year later than the one who tried to prove they didn't need any

GOAL OF MODULE 2

Every manager understands that authority is given but respect is earned, that letting go of hands-on work is the price of building a capable team, and that a deliberate first ninety days builds far more credibility than reacting one issue at a time.

MODULE 3 — The Motos America Leadership Standard

MODULE 02 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to this module, what is the difference between authority and respect?
 - A. Neither can be earned — both depend entirely on tenure
 - B. Authority is granted with the title; respect has to be earned through consistent behavior
 - C. They are the same thing and are granted together
 - D. Respect is granted with the title; authority must be earned
2. In the WEAK/STRONG example about managing former peers, what does the STRONG version do that the WEAK version doesn't?
 - A. It promises the relationship won't change at all
 - B. It threatens consequences for underperformance
 - C. It names the awkwardness directly, reaffirms the relationship, and is honest about the new role
 - D. It avoids the topic entirely to keep things comfortable
3. What trap does the module warn against when managing a former peer?
 - A. Holding them to a higher standard than the rest of the team
 - B. Meeting with them one-on-one too frequently
 - C. Managing them more gently than the rest of the team out of guilt
 - D. Being too direct too soon
4. According to Part 3, what happens when a manager constantly steps in to do a task faster themselves?
 - A. It builds trust with the team member being helped
 - B. The team becomes more efficient over time
 - C. It has no meaningful effect on team development
 - D. It saves time today but prevents the team from building the skill long-term
5. What is the most common mistake new managers make in their first ninety days, according to this module?
 - A. Asking other department managers for help too early
 - B. Waiting too long to set any goals at all
 - C. Meeting individually with every team member
 - D. Arriving with a list of changes before understanding why things are the way they are

MODULE 03

The Motos America Leadership Standard

Culture isn't the sentence painted on the wall. It's whatever the manager tolerates on a busy Saturday when nobody's watching.

Every employee at Motos America hears "Live the Passion. Take the Ride." during their own department academy. What they actually believe about that phrase — whether it's a real operating standard or just a slogan — gets decided almost entirely by what they watch their manager do, especially under pressure. You don't set culture by talking about it. You set it by what you model, what you correct, and what you let slide.

PART 1

CULTURE IS WHAT YOU TOLERATE

Every department already has a culture, whether or not anyone designed it on purpose. If a manager lets a good employee cut corners because they're a top performer, that becomes the culture. If a manager consistently shows up late to their own huddles, punctuality becomes optional in practice, no matter what the handbook says. Employees are far more perceptive than managers often give them credit for — they don't listen to what you say the standard is nearly as closely as they watch what you actually enforce.

- ▶ A standard you state once and never enforce isn't a standard — it's a suggestion
- ▶ A standard you enforce consistently, even in small moments, becomes the water your team swims in
- ▶ The fastest way to destroy a strong culture is to have one standard for your favorite employees and another for everyone else

YOUR TEAM'S STANDARD IS WHATEVER YOU'RE WILLING TO WALK PAST WITHOUT SAYING ANYTHING

PART 2

THE STATE RITUAL AS A LEADERSHIP TOOL

You were introduced to the State Ritual — Breath Up, Posture Up, Focus Up with your North Star, Smile and Move — in your department academy, and to its leadership application briefly in Module 1. Here's the deeper version: a manager's state is contagious in both directions. Walk onto the floor rattled, distracted, or short-tempered, and within the hour, some version of that mood is showing up in how your team treats customers and each other. Walk in centered and present, and that steadiness spreads too — often without you saying a single word about it.

This isn't about pretending everything is fine when it isn't. It's about handling your own state deliberately, on purpose, before you lead anyone else through theirs.

- ▶ Before a huddle, a difficult conversation, or a walk onto a busy floor, take fifteen seconds to actually run the Ritual rather than skipping straight to the interaction
- ▶ If you're having a genuinely hard day, it's fine to be honest about that with your team in age-appropriate terms — what erodes trust is pretending nothing's wrong while your behavior says otherwise
- ▶ Your North Star as a manager isn't just your own "why" anymore — it's a reminder of the standard you're responsible for carrying into every room you walk into

PART 3

EVERY EMPLOYEE IS AN AMBASSADOR — AND YOU SET THE TONE FOR WHAT THAT MEANS

Every academy teaches that customers don't distinguish between departments — to them, there's one dealership, one relationship, one brand. As a manager, you're the person most responsible for making that true in practice. Your department's reputation, in the eyes of every other department and every customer who passes through it, is a direct reflection of the standard you hold.

- ▶ A Sales Manager who lets deals get made with sloppy paperwork puts F&I and every downstream department in a worse position
- ▶ A Service Manager who tolerates rushed inspections puts the customer's safety, and the dealership's reputation, at risk the next time that bike is on the road
- ▶ A Parts Manager who lets the rear counter treat technicians as an afterthought slows down the entire shop, not just Parts

Every department's standard is a link in a chain that customers and coworkers alike depend on. Weak links don't stay contained to one department for long.

PART 4

PASSPORT IS A MANAGER'S JOB, NOT JUST AN EMPLOYEE SKILL

Passport Academy teaches every customer-facing employee how to personally introduce a customer to the next department, rather than simply pointing and hoping for the best. What Passport Academy doesn't — and can't — teach is what happens when nobody's actively coaching that skill after training ends. That part is yours.

It's easy for Passport to quietly erode over time. A busy Saturday, a short-staffed shift, a new hire who was never quite walked through it properly — small gaps that don't look like much individually but add up to customers feeling "passed around" instead of personally handed off. Watching for that erosion, and coaching it back into shape, is a standing part of your job, not a one-time training topic you can consider finished.

WEAK: *(overhearing a team member simply tell a customer "Parts is over there") "...I'll let it go, they're busy."*

STRONG: *"Hey, quick thing — next time, walk them over and introduce them by name if you can, even just a 'hey Mike, this is Sarah, she's looking for a new helmet.' Takes ten extra seconds and makes a real difference in how it feels on their end. Let's build that habit back in."*

- ▶ Watch for Passport handoffs during normal operations, not just during formal training
- ▶ Correct gaps in the moment, briefly and without embarrassing the employee in front of a customer
- ▶ Model the handoff yourself periodically — your team should see you doing it, not just enforcing it

PART 5

CONSISTENCY ACROSS SHIFTS, DAYS, AND MOODS

The standard that only holds up when you're personally present isn't a real standard — it's supervision. The goal is a department that holds its own standard on a Tuesday afternoon with you in a meeting off-site exactly as well as it does on a Saturday with you standing on the floor.

- ▶ Build the standard into how you train and coach, not just into what you personally enforce in the moment
- ▶ Give your strongest team members real ownership of upholding the standard with newer employees — it multiplies your presence instead of depending on it

- ▶ If the department only performs well when you're watching, that's a coaching gap to close, not a compliment about your presence

A STANDARD THAT ONLY HOLDS WHEN THE MANAGER IS WATCHING ISN'T A CULTURE. IT'S A PERFORMANCE FOR AN AUDIENCE OF ONE

GOAL OF MODULE 3

Every manager understands that culture is defined by what's tolerated, not what's stated; that the State Ritual is a leadership tool as much as a personal one; and that Passport is a standing coaching responsibility they personally own, not a training topic that's ever fully "done."

MODULE 4 — Understanding Your Team's Core Needs

MODULE 03 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to this module, what actually determines a department's culture?
 - A. The mission statement posted in the break room
 - B. How long the department has been operating
 - C. The department's monthly sales numbers
 - D. What the manager tolerates and enforces, not what they state
2. According to Part 2, why is a manager's state described as "contagious in both directions"?
 - A. It only affects the manager's own performance
 - B. It only matters during scheduled one-on-ones
 - C. It affects customers but not coworkers
 - D. A manager's mood, whether rattled or centered, tends to spread to how the team behaves within the hour
3. What does this module say is the risk of a Sales Manager tolerating sloppy paperwork on deals?
 - A. It only affects the customer's experience at delivery
 - B. It puts F&I and downstream departments in a worse position
 - C. It only becomes a problem if corporate audits the deal
 - D. It has no effect outside the Sales department
4. According to Part 4, what is the manager's specific responsibility regarding Passport after initial training is complete?
 - A. Personally handling every customer handoff themselves
 - B. Re-running Passport Academy training every quarter
 - C. Continuously watching for erosion in handoffs and coaching it back into shape
 - D. None — Passport Academy fully covers ongoing execution
5. What does this module say about a department that only performs well when the manager is physically present?
 - A. It reflects a coaching gap, not a genuine culture
 - B. It means the team needs stricter written policies
 - C. It indicates the manager should reduce their presence on the floor
 - D. That's the expected and desired outcome of good management

MODULE 04

Understanding Your Team's Core Needs

Two employees can hear the exact same feedback and walk away with completely different reactions — not because one is more sensitive, but because they're wired to need different things from the work.

Every manager eventually runs into the same puzzle: the incentive plan that lit one employee up did nothing for another. The praise that made one person glow left another person shrugging. The schedule change that felt like an insult to one felt like a relief to someone else. None of that is random. Beneath almost every reaction your team has — good, bad, or confusing — is a small set of underlying needs driving the behavior. Learn to read them, and a huge amount of what used to seem unpredictable about managing people starts making a lot more sense.

PART 1

BEHAVIOR IS RARELY ABOUT WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE ON THE SURFACE

When an employee is chronically late, the surface explanation is usually "they don't care" or "they're disorganized." Sometimes that's true. Just as often, something underneath the behavior is doing real work — a need for certainty they don't feel they have, a craving for significance they're not getting through normal channels, a disconnection from the team that makes showing up on time feel less urgent than it should.

This isn't an excuse-generating exercise, and it doesn't mean every late arrival gets explained away. It means a manager who only addresses the surface behavior — write them up, threaten consequences, repeat — often sees the same problem resurface in a different form later, because the underlying driver was never actually addressed.

- ▶ Surface-level management treats every performance issue the same way: consequence, repeat, escalate
- ▶ Needs-aware management asks what's actually driving the behavior before deciding how to respond
- ▶ The response to a genuine skill gap, a motivation gap, and an unmet personal need are three completely different conversations — even when the visible symptom looks identical

PART 2

SIX THINGS EVERY PERSON ON YOUR TEAM IS QUIETLY SEEKING

Underneath almost any workplace behavior, you'll find some combination of six underlying needs at play. None of these are unique to Motos America — they show up in every workplace, every relationship, every team — but recognizing them by name makes them far easier to spot and respond to in the moment.

- ▶ *Certainty.* The need to feel safe, stable, and able to predict what happens next — a clear schedule, clear expectations, a manager who doesn't blindside people.
- ▶ *Variety.* The need for change, challenge, and something new — the opposite pull from certainty, and one every team has some mix of both types in.
- ▶ *Significance.* The need to feel important, needed, and recognized — to matter, and to know that others notice it.
- ▶ *Connection.* The need to feel close to, liked by, and part of something with other people — genuine belonging, not just proximity.

- ▶ *Growth.* The need to be developing, improving, and becoming more capable over time.
- ▶ *Contribution.* The need to feel that the work matters beyond the paycheck — that it makes a real difference to someone.

Everyone has all six to some degree. What varies dramatically from person to person is which one or two are running the show at any given time — and that's usually the fastest lever a manager has for reaching someone.

PART 3

READING WHICH NEED IS DRIVING A GIVEN EMPLOYEE

You don't need a personality test to spot this — you need attention. Watch for what people gravitate toward and complain about, and the pattern usually reveals itself within a few weeks of paying real attention.

- ▶ The employee who resists every schedule change, even minor ones, is often running high on a need for certainty
- ▶ The employee who gets restless doing the same task for more than a few weeks is often running high on a need for variety
- ▶ The employee whose mood visibly lifts after being publicly recognized, and who seems to fish for credit, is often running high on a need for significance
- ▶ The employee who seems to care more about team lunches and inside jokes than almost anything else is often running high on a need for connection
- ▶ The employee who asks the most questions about "what's next for me here" is often running high on a need for growth
- ▶ The employee who lights up most when a customer specifically thanks them, more than when a manager does, is often running high on a need for contribution

None of these are fixed labels — the same person can lean on different needs depending on what's happening in their life at the time. Treat this as a lens to check in with periodically, not a permanent file you build once and never revisit.

PART 4

MEETING A NEED VERSUS FAKING RECOGNITION

WEAK: *"Great job this month, everyone. Keep it up!"* — said the same way, to the whole team, regardless of what actually happened or who needs to hear what.

STRONG: *"Marcus, I want to call out specifically what you did with that return last week — that customer could've walked out furious, and instead they left thanking you by name. That's exactly the kind of judgment call I trust you with, and I want you to know I noticed it."*

The strong version works because it's specific, it's tied to something real, and it lands directly on a need — in this case, significance — instead of being generic praise that could apply to anyone. Generic recognition is easy to give and easy to forget. Specific recognition, aimed at what actually matters to that person, is what people remember months later.

- ▶ For an employee driven by growth, the equivalent might be a specific new responsibility rather than praise at all
- ▶ For an employee driven by connection, it might be as simple as remembering something personal they mentioned and following up on it later
- ▶ Generic, one-size-fits-all recognition isn't wrong — it's just far weaker than recognition aimed at what the person actually needs

PART 5

WHEN A NEED COLLIDES WITH THE JOB

Sometimes a role and a person's dominant need are naturally mismatched — a high-variety employee stuck in a highly repetitive part of the job, for example. This doesn't automatically mean the wrong hire was made. It usually means a manager has to get a little more creative about where variety, growth, or contribution shows up elsewhere in that person's week.

- ▶ Rotating a high-variety employee through different tasks, even briefly, can meaningfully improve their engagement without changing their core role
- ▶ A high-growth employee stuck at a plateau benefits enormously from being looped into cross-training — see Modules 12 through 15 — even before a promotion is realistically on the table
- ▶ Not every mismatch is fixable. Occasionally the honest answer is that a role and a person's core drivers simply don't fit long-term, and that's worth recognizing rather than fighting indefinitely

PART 6

NEEDS AREN'T EXCUSES

Understanding what's driving someone's behavior is not the same as excusing poor performance or bad behavior because of it. A manager who says "well, they just have a high need for significance, that's why they took credit for their teammate's work" has confused insight with license. Use this framework to understand people better and coach them more effectively — never as a justification for lowering the standard.

UNDERSTANDING WHY SOMEONE IS STRUGGLING MAKES YOU A BETTER COACH. IT DOESN'T LOWER WHAT YOU EXPECT FROM THEM

GOAL OF MODULE 4

Every manager can name the six underlying needs that drive behavior, recognize which ones are showing up most strongly in individual team members, and use that insight to coach and recognize people more effectively — without ever treating it as an excuse for the standard slipping.

MODULE 5 — State Management for Leaders

MODULE 04 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

- 1. According to this module, why does surface-level management (consequence, repeat, escalate) often fail to fix a recurring performance issue?**
 - A. It takes too long to implement consistently
 - B. Employees don't respond to consequences of any kind
 - C. Consequences are never appropriate in a management setting
 - D. It doesn't address the underlying driver of the behavior, so the same problem tends to resurface

- 2. Which of the following is one of the six underlying needs described in this module?**
 - A. Seniority
 - B. Punctuality
 - C. Compensation
 - D. Certainty

- 3. In the recognition example, why does the STRONG version work better than the WEAK version?**
 - A. It's shorter than the WEAK version
 - B. It's delivered in a team meeting instead of privately
 - C. It's specific, tied to something real, and aimed at what the individual actually needs
 - D. It promises a raise

- 4. According to Part 5, what's a reasonable response when an employee's dominant need doesn't naturally fit their day-to-day role?**
 - A. Ignore it, since needs shouldn't affect job design
 - B. Get creative about where that need can be met elsewhere in their week, such as through cross-training
 - C. Immediately reassign or terminate the employee
 - D. Increase their pay to compensate

- 5. According to Part 6, what is the correct use of this needs framework?**
 - A. As a replacement for performance reviews
 - B. As a way to understand and coach people more effectively, without lowering the standard
 - C. As a tool to explain away poor performance or behavior
 - D. As a way to lower expectations for employees with strong needs

MODULE 05

State Management for Leaders

Two managers can get the exact same piece of bad news. One walks onto the floor five minutes later and the whole team feels it. The other walks onto the floor and nobody outside the office even knows anything happened. The difference isn't the news — it's what happened in between.

Every manager gets hit with bad news. A no-show on a Saturday. A customer escalation that's about to go sideways. A number that's badly missing target with three days left in the month. What separates managers who lead well under pressure from managers who don't isn't whether hard things happen to them — hard things happen to everyone in this role eventually. It's what they do with their own state in the minutes right after, before anyone else sees them.

PART 1

YOUR STATE IS THE FIRST THING YOUR TEAM READS

Long before your team hears what you have to say about a problem, they read your face, your posture, your tone. Walk in tight-jawed and clipped, and the team braces for something bad before you've said a word — and that bracing itself changes how they perform for the next hour, regardless of whether the actual news affects them directly. Walk in steady, even while delivering difficult news, and the team takes their emotional cue from you instead of spiraling on their own.

- ▶ Your team can't see the problem you're carrying. They can only see how you're carrying it
- ▶ A manager who looks rattled communicates, without saying so, that the situation is worse than it is
- ▶ A manager who stays visibly steady — not fake, not falsely cheerful, just steady — gives the team permission to stay steady too

A LEADER'S STATE ARRIVES IN THE ROOM A FULL BEAT BEFORE THE LEADER'S WORDS DO

PART 2

WHAT HAPPENS, THE STORY, AND THE STRATEGY

Nearly every difficult moment breaks down into three separate pieces, and most people collapse all three together without realizing it: something happens, you tell yourself a story about what it means, and you choose a strategy based on that story — often without noticing the story was ever a choice at all.

Take a real example: an employee doesn't show up for their Saturday shift, no call. *What happens* is simply that: nobody showed, no call came in. Everything after that is story. "They don't respect me." "They're irresponsible." "This is going to blow up the whole day." None of those are facts yet — they're interpretations, and each one leads to a very different strategy. A manager who runs straight from the event to the angriest possible story will walk into that Saturday already in a fight, before they've even confirmed what actually happened.

- ▶ *What happened* is the only part that's actually fact — everything else is interpretation
- ▶ The story you tell yourself in the first sixty seconds almost always determines the tone of everything that follows
- ▶ Pausing long enough to notice you're choosing a story — rather than assuming it's simply the truth — is the single highest-leverage habit in this entire module

PART 3

CATCHING THE STORY BEFORE IT RUNS THE ROOM

The goal isn't to eliminate the story — your brain will generate one automatically, every time, whether you want it to or not. The goal is to catch it before you act on it, and ask a simple question: is this the only story that fits the facts, or just the first one my brain reached for?

- ▶ Ask yourself what a more generous interpretation of the same facts might be, even if you don't fully believe it yet
- ▶ Ask what you'd tell a manager on your own team if they came to you with this exact situation and this exact story
- ▶ Notice that the strategy almost always improves the moment the story does, even before you've gathered a single new fact

Back to the no-show example: "they don't respect me" leads to a tense, accusatory conversation on Monday. "Something might genuinely be wrong, and I won't know until I ask" leads to a very different conversation — one that's far more likely to actually get to the truth, and far less likely to damage the relationship if the explanation turns out to be legitimate.

PART 4

REACTING VERSUS RESPONDING

WEAK: *(phone buzzes with a customer escalation mid-shift)* "Are you KIDDING me right now? What else is going to go wrong today?" — said loudly enough that three team members hear it and immediately brace.

STRONG: *(same buzz, same escalation)* Manager takes a breath, steps slightly away from the floor, reads the full message before reacting to any of it, then returns and says calmly: "Alright, we've got a situation with a customer — nothing anyone here did wrong that I can see yet. I'm going to go handle it. Keep doing what you're doing."

The strong version isn't about suppressing the frustration — it's completely normal to feel it. It's about not broadcasting the rawest version of that reaction to a team that will absorb it and carry it into their own interactions for the rest of the shift. A fifteen-second pause between the trigger and the response is almost always enough.

PART 5

BUILDING YOUR OWN RESET PRACTICE

You already have a tool for this — the State Ritual you've carried since your own department academy. Under real pressure, most managers skip it entirely, precisely when they need it most, because it starts to feel like a nicety rather than a necessity. Treat it instead as a non-negotiable step between a hard trigger and your next action, the same way you'd never skip a safety step just because you were in a hurry.

- ▶ Before delivering hard news to your team, take the fifteen seconds. It will not make you look slow — it will make what you say next land better
- ▶ If a moment is too fast-moving to pause for a full Ritual, even a single deliberate breath before speaking makes a measurable difference
- ▶ Notice which triggers hit you hardest — a specific type of customer complaint, a specific number missing target — and expect your reset practice to matter most exactly there

PART 6

LEADING YOUR TEAM'S STATE, NOT JUST YOUR OWN

Once you've managed your own state, the job extends one layer further: managing the state of the room. A team that's rattled performs worse, treats customers worse, and treats each other worse — all measurably, not just in a vague sense. Part of your job on a genuinely chaotic day is actively working to keep the room steady, not simply surviving it yourself.

- ▶ Naming the chaos out loud, calmly, often does more to settle a team than pretending it isn't happening
- ▶ A short, honest huddle — "today's rough, here's the plan, let's get through it together" — resets a room faster than silence does
- ▶ The manager who stays visibly steady on the worst days is the manager a team will follow through the next one without hesitation

GOAL OF MODULE 5

Every manager can separate what happened from the story they're telling themselves about it, catch that story before it drives a reaction, and use a deliberate reset practice to lead their own state — and their team's — through real pressure.

MODULE 6 — Hiring & Onboarding Right

MODULE 05 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what does a team read before a manager says anything about a problem?
 - A. The department's monthly sales report
 - B. Nothing — teams only respond to explicit instructions
 - C. The manager's state — face, posture, and tone
 - D. The customer's reaction, not the manager's
2. In the "what happens, the story, and the strategy" framework, what is the only part of a difficult moment that's actually fact?
 - A. What literally happened, before any interpretation is added
 - B. The story told about what it means
 - C. The strategy chosen in response
 - D. The manager's initial emotional reaction
3. According to Part 3, what question helps a manager catch a story before acting on it?
 - A. "Who is responsible for this?"
 - B. "How do I make this someone else's problem?"
 - C. "Is this the only story that fits the facts, or just the first one my brain reached for?"
 - D. "What would corporate want me to do?"
4. In the WEAK/STRONG example about the customer escalation, what does the STRONG version demonstrate?
 - A. Ignoring the escalation until the end of the shift
 - B. Delegating the escalation immediately without reading it
 - C. A brief pause before reacting, and not broadcasting the rawest reaction to the team
 - D. Suppressing all frustration so it's never felt
5. According to Part 6, what is the effect of a manager staying visibly steady during a chaotic day?
 - A. It makes the team think the manager doesn't understand the severity of the situation
 - B. It settles the room and builds the kind of trust a team follows through the next hard day
 - C. It only affects how customers perceive the manager, not the team
 - D. It has no measurable effect on the team's performance

MODULE 06

Hiring & Onboarding Right

A great hire makes every part of your job easier for years. A bad hire makes every part of your job harder for exactly as long as it takes you to fix it — and fixing it always takes longer than it should have taken to prevent.

Of every decision a manager makes, none compounds harder than who joins the team. A strong hire lifts the people around them, absorbs training quickly, and often becomes someone you can eventually promote. A poor hire drains your time, drags down morale, and — if it goes on too long — quietly signals to your best people that the standard isn't really being protected. Hiring well is not a distraction from the "real" work of managing. It is some of the highest-leverage work you'll ever do.

PART 1

THE TRUE COST OF A BAD HIRE

New managers often underestimate how expensive a wrong hire actually is, because the cost rarely shows up as a single line item. It shows up as the extra hours retraining, the customers who had a mediocre experience along the way, the good employees who quietly start looking elsewhere because they're carrying the slack, and eventually the cost of replacing the person anyway — after months of lost ground instead of before.

- ▶ A bad hire rarely fails loudly and immediately — it's usually a slow leak, which makes it tempting to keep hoping it'll improve
- ▶ The cost of moving too fast to fill an open seat is almost always higher than the cost of running the seat short-staffed a little longer
- ▶ Your best employees notice when a struggling teammate isn't addressed, and it affects how hard they're willing to work for you

A SEAT LEFT OPEN A FEW EXTRA WEEKS COSTS YOU LESS THAN A SEAT FILLED WITH THE WRONG PERSON FOR A FEW EXTRA MONTHS

PART 2

HIRE FOR STANDARD, TRAIN FOR SKILL

Every academy in this university can teach a motivated person how to greet a customer, read a repair order, or build an accessory package. No academy can install character, coachability, or genuine care for people from scratch. When evaluating a candidate, weigh how trainable the skill gap is against how fixable the character gap is — and be honest that one of those is far easier to close than the other.

- ▶ Skill gaps are usually closeable within weeks through the right academy and real coaching
- ▶ Attitude, coachability, and honesty gaps rarely close through training alone, no matter how good the manual is
- ▶ A candidate with modest experience but real coachability and a strong work ethic is almost always a better long-term hire than an experienced candidate who seems difficult to coach

This doesn't mean skill is irrelevant — a role like a technician or an experienced F&I professional carries a real skill floor a candidate has to clear. It means that above that floor, character should carry more weight in your decision than most new managers instinctively give it.

PART 3

ASKING QUESTIONS THAT ACTUALLY TELL YOU SOMETHING

Generic interview questions produce generic, rehearsed answers. The goal of an interview isn't to hear the right buzzwords — it's to hear how someone actually thinks and behaves, which usually only comes out through specific, real examples.

WEAK: *"Are you a team player?"* — every candidate says yes, regardless of whether it's true.

STRONG: *"Tell me about a time you disagreed with a manager's decision at a previous job. What did you do?"*

WEAK: *"Do you handle stress well?"*

STRONG: *"Walk me through the busiest, most chaotic shift you've ever worked. What actually happened, and what did you do?"*

Behavioral questions like the strong versions are harder to fake because they require a real memory, not a rehearsed value statement. Listen closely to how the candidate talks about other people in the story — respectfully or dismissively — and how much ownership they take for their own role in the outcome, good or bad.

- ▶ Ask for specific examples, not hypotheticals — hypotheticals reveal what someone thinks they'd do, not what they actually do
- ▶ Notice whether a candidate takes any ownership when a story doesn't go well, or whether every setback is someone else's fault
- ▶ Silence after a question is not a problem to rescue the candidate from — give them the space to actually think

PART 4

RED FLAGS WORTH SLOWING DOWN FOR

No single red flag automatically disqualifies a candidate, but a pattern of them is worth taking seriously rather than talking yourself out of, especially when you're under pressure to fill a seat quickly.

- ▶ Consistently blaming previous managers or coworkers for every past problem, with no ownership anywhere in the story
- ▶ Vague or evasive answers about why they left their last several positions
- ▶ Treating the interview itself — being on time, being prepared, being respectful to everyone they encounter on the way in, not just the interviewer — as optional
- ▶ A gut feeling that something's off, even if you can't fully articulate why. That instinct is often picking up on something real

Being short-staffed creates real pressure to fill the seat quickly. That pressure is exactly when hiring standards quietly slip the most — which is exactly why it's worth naming and resisting deliberately.

PART 5

THE FIRST DAY SETS THE TONE

A new hire's first day shapes their expectations of the entire job, often permanently. A disorganized, "figure it out as you go" first day quietly communicates that the department itself is disorganized — even if that's not usually true. A well-run first day communicates the opposite, immediately.

- ▶ Have their workspace, schedule, and academy assignment ready before they arrive — not scrambled together the morning of
- ▶ Personally spend real time with them on day one, rather than handing them off entirely to a peer

- ▶ Introduce them around using the same Passport-style handoff standard you expect them to eventually use with customers — a small but meaningful way to model the standard from their very first hour

PART 6

A STRUCTURED FIRST NINETY DAYS FOR NEW HIRES

Just as you built a deliberate first ninety days for yourself in Module 2, a new hire benefits from the same intentional structure rather than being left to sink or swim.

- ▶ *Days 1–30:* Academy training, shadowing your strongest team members, and frequent short check-ins — daily at first, tapering as confidence builds
- ▶ *Days 31–60:* Increasing independence with a clear safety net; regular coaching on real interactions rather than only hypothetical training scenarios
- ▶ *Days 61–90:* A formal check-in on how they're settling in, honest feedback in both directions, and a clear-eyed decision about fit if real concerns have surfaced

Treat the ninety-day mark as a genuine decision point, not a formality to rubber-stamp. It's far easier — for both the department and the new hire — to make an honest call at ninety days than to let a poor fit drag on for a year out of momentum or discomfort.

GOAL OF MODULE 6

Every manager understands that hiring is one of their highest-leverage decisions, weighs coachable character over easily-trainable skill, asks behavioral rather than generic interview questions, and runs a deliberate first ninety days for every new hire rather than leaving onboarding to chance.

MODULE 7 — *Coaching Conversations That Work*

MODULE 06 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, why do managers often underestimate the true cost of a bad hire?
 - A. The cost shows up gradually, as a slow leak, rather than as a single visible line item
 - B. Bad hires always fail loudly and immediately, so the cost is obvious
 - C. Corporate absorbs the entire cost of a bad hire
 - D. Bad hires are always caught during the interview process
2. According to Part 2, what is generally easier to close through training: a skill gap or a character gap?
 - A. A skill gap
 - B. Both are equally easy to close
 - C. Neither can be closed through training
 - D. A character gap
3. Why does the module say behavioral interview questions are harder to fake than generic ones?
 - A. They focus only on technical skills
 - B. Candidates are given the questions in advance
 - C. They are always asked in a group interview setting
 - D. They require a specific, real memory rather than a rehearsed value statement
4. According to Part 4, what should a manager do when hiring pressure to fill a seat quickly starts to affect their standards?
 - A. Ignore red flags since being short-staffed is worse
 - B. Lower the standard temporarily until the seat is filled
 - C. Hand the decision off to HR entirely
 - D. Recognize that pressure and resist letting hiring standards slip
5. According to Part 6, what should happen at the ninety-day mark for a new hire?
 - A. A genuine decision point with honest feedback in both directions, including an honest look at fit
 - B. A formal write-up if any mistakes were made in the first ninety days
 - C. Automatic advancement to full independence regardless of performance
 - D. Nothing formal — the new hire is simply left to continue as-is

MODULE 07

Coaching Conversations That Work

Correcting fixes a moment. Coaching fixes a pattern.

Every manager corrects people — it's part of the job. Far fewer managers actually coach, and the difference matters more than it sounds like it should. Correcting tells someone what they did wrong. Coaching helps someone understand why it happened and builds their own ability to catch it next time, without you standing there. A department full of people who've only ever been corrected needs a manager in the room at all times. A department full of people who've actually been coached can hold the standard whether you're there or not.

PART 1

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN CORRECTING AND COACHING

Correcting is fast, one-directional, and often happens in the heat of the moment: "don't do it that way, do it this way." It has its place — some moments genuinely call for a quick correction and nothing more. But used as the only tool, it produces employees who wait to be told rather than employees who think for themselves.

Coaching is slower, asks more than it tells, and builds a skill the employee can use the next time you're not standing there to catch it. It takes more time in the moment and pays that time back many times over.

- ▶ Correcting says "here's what to do." Coaching asks "what do you think went wrong, and what would you try differently?"
- ▶ Correcting builds compliance. Coaching builds judgment
- ▶ A team that's only ever corrected needs constant supervision. A team that's been coached can be trusted with more, because they've actually built the underlying skill

IF YOU'RE STILL CORRECTING THE SAME MISTAKE A MONTH LATER, THE PROBLEM ISN'T THE EMPLOYEE — IT'S THAT YOU'VE BEEN CORRECTING INSTEAD OF COACHING

PART 2

A SIMPLE STRUCTURE FOR ANY COACHING CONVERSATION

Good coaching conversations tend to follow a similar shape, whether they're thirty seconds on the floor or a sit-down in your office: observe specifically, ask before telling, listen for real understanding, and guide toward the next attempt rather than simply toward the right answer.

- ▶ *Observe specifically.* Vague feedback like "that could've gone better" gives someone nothing to actually work with. Name exactly what you saw.
- ▶ *Ask before telling.* Give the employee the first shot at diagnosing what happened. People retain their own conclusions far better than conclusions handed to them.
- ▶ *Listen for real understanding, not just agreement.* Nodding along isn't the same as actually grasping what went wrong — ask a follow-up if you're not sure which one you're getting.
- ▶ *Guide toward the next attempt.* End with something concrete they can actually try differently next time, not just a diagnosis of what went wrong last time.

PART 3

IN-THE-MOMENT COACHING VERSUS SIT-DOWN COACHING

Not every coaching moment needs a formal meeting, and treating every single one like a big deal actually works against you — it makes small, everyday coaching feel heavier than it needs to, and employees start to dread even minor feedback.

- ▶ Small, in-the-moment coaching — thirty seconds, right after the interaction, in a low-key tone — is the majority of what good coaching actually looks like day to day
- ▶ Sit-down coaching is reserved for patterns, not single incidents: something that's happened more than once, or something significant enough to need real focus and follow-up
- ▶ Save the phrase "can we talk for a minute" for things that actually warrant it — overusing it for small stuff trains people to brace every time they hear it

PART 4

COACHING IN ACTION: TWO EXAMPLES

WEAK: *(after overhearing a rushed customer interaction) "You were kind of short with that customer. Try to be nicer."*

STRONG: *"Hey, got a second? I noticed you jumped straight to the price when that customer asked about the jacket, before finding out what they actually needed it for. What do you think happened there?"*
[employee responds] *"Yeah, that tracks — next time, try leading with one question about how they'll actually use it. See how that changes the conversation."*

WEAK: *(reviewing a missed upsell opportunity in a one-on-one) "You need to upsell more. Your numbers show you're not doing it."*

STRONG: *"I pulled a few of your tickets from this week — on three of them, there was a natural opening for an add-on that didn't get mentioned. Walk me through one of them. What were you thinking in that moment?"* [employee responds, reveals hesitation about seeming pushy] *"That makes sense — a lot of people worry about that. Here's a version that doesn't feel pushy at all: [specific example]. Want to try that one this week and we'll check back in?"*

Notice that both STRONG versions uncover the actual reason behind the behavior before offering a fix. The WEAK versions jump straight to the correction and miss the real cause entirely — in the second example, a generic "upsell more" completely misses that the real issue was hesitation about seeming pushy, not a lack of product knowledge.

PART 5

COACHING DIFFERENT PEOPLE DIFFERENTLY

The core structure — observe, ask, listen, guide — stays the same for everyone. How you deliver it should flex based on what you already know about the person, including the underlying needs covered in Module 4.

- ▶ An employee driven by significance often responds best to coaching that starts by acknowledging what they did well before addressing what to improve
- ▶ An employee driven by certainty often needs the "why" behind a change spelled out clearly, or the new approach can feel arbitrary rather than genuinely better
- ▶ An employee driven by growth often responds well to coaching framed explicitly as building toward the next level, not just fixing today's mistake

This isn't about treating people unequally — it's about recognizing that identical words can land very differently depending on who's hearing them, and adjusting delivery while keeping the standard itself completely consistent.

PART 6

WHEN COACHING ISN'T LANDING

Most performance issues respond to consistent coaching over a reasonable period of time. Some don't — and recognizing the difference matters. If you've coached the same issue clearly, more than once, with real effort on both sides, and nothing is changing, that's a signal the conversation needs to shift from coaching toward a more formal performance conversation.

- ▶ One missed coaching moment is normal. The same issue, coached clearly, three or more times with no change is a pattern worth escalating
- ▶ Document what you've coached and when, even informally — it protects both you and the employee if a formal conversation becomes necessary later
- ▶ Moving to a formal conversation isn't a failure of your coaching. Some issues genuinely require it, and Module 8 covers exactly how to run that conversation well

GOAL OF MODULE 7

Every manager can run a coaching conversation that observes specifically, asks before telling, listens for real understanding, and guides toward a concrete next attempt — flexing delivery to the individual while recognizing when a pattern has moved beyond what coaching alone can fix.

MODULE 8 — Performance Reviews & Difficult Conversations

MODULE 07 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what is the key difference between correcting and coaching?
 - A. There is no meaningful difference between the two
 - B. Correcting fixes a single moment; coaching builds a skill the employee can use without the manager present
 - C. Correcting takes longer than coaching
 - D. Coaching is only used for new hires
2. What are the four steps of the coaching structure described in Part 2?
 - A. Praise, correct, praise, dismiss
 - B. Assign, inspect, report, review
 - C. Observe specifically, ask before telling, listen for real understanding, guide toward the next attempt
 - D. Warn, write up, monitor, escalate
3. According to Part 3, when should sit-down coaching be used instead of in-the-moment coaching?
 - A. For every single coaching moment, regardless of size
 - B. For patterns or significant issues, not single small incidents
 - C. Only during scheduled annual reviews
 - D. Never — in-the-moment coaching should always be used
4. In the second coaching example (the missed upsell), what did the STRONG version uncover that the WEAK version missed?
 - A. The employee didn't understand the product
 - B. The employee hadn't been trained on that product line
 - C. The employee was hesitant about seeming pushy, not lacking product knowledge
 - D. The employee disagreed with the company's upsell policy
5. According to Part 6, what signals that a coaching issue should move toward a formal performance conversation?
 - A. The employee asking clarifying questions during coaching
 - B. Any single instance of a mistake
 - C. The employee disagreeing with the manager's feedback
 - D. The same issue, coached clearly more than once, with no real change

MODULE 08

Performance Reviews & Difficult Conversations

The conversation you're avoiding right now is the one your best employees are wondering why you haven't had yet.

Every manager has at least one conversation they've been putting off — the employee whose performance has quietly slipped, the attitude problem nobody's directly named, the number that's been off for two months running. Avoiding it feels safer in the moment. It rarely is. The team almost always sees the problem before the manager finally addresses it, and every week it goes unaddressed, it quietly teaches the rest of the team that the standard is negotiable.

PART 1

WHY THESE CONVERSATIONS GET AVOIDED — AND WHAT IT COSTS

Nobody enjoys telling another adult their performance isn't where it needs to be. It's uncomfortable, it can feel confrontational, and there's always a version of the story where things quietly improve on their own and the conversation never has to happen. That version almost never actually plays out.

- ▶ Avoided conversations don't stay small — they accumulate, until what should have been a five-minute coaching moment becomes a much harder conversation about a much bigger pattern
- ▶ Your strongest performers are watching whether underperformance gets addressed. Every week it doesn't, it costs you a little of their respect and effort
- ▶ The discomfort of having the conversation is temporary. The cost of not having it compounds for as long as you avoid it

THE CONVERSATION YOU'RE DREADING TODAY IS ALMOST ALWAYS EASIER THAN THE ONE YOU'LL BE HAVING IN THREE MONTHS IF YOU KEEP PUTTING IT OFF

PART 2

PREPARING BEFORE YOU SIT DOWN

A difficult conversation that isn't prepared for tends to drift, get emotional, or leave both people unclear on what actually needs to change. A few minutes of preparation makes an enormous difference in how the conversation actually goes.

- ▶ Get specific before you walk in — "your attitude has been off" is much harder to act on than "you've been short with three customers this week that I've personally witnessed"
- ▶ Know what outcome you actually want from the conversation before it starts — a changed behavior, a clear understanding, a documented starting point — rather than walking in only knowing what you're upset about
- ▶ If this is a pattern you've already coached before, per Module 7, have that history in mind — this conversation should reference it, not start from zero as if it's the first time

PART 3

A STRUCTURE THAT KEEPS THE CONVERSATION ON TRACK

A simple structure keeps a hard conversation from drifting into vague accusations or a purely emotional exchange: describe the specific situation, name the specific behavior you observed, explain the impact it's having, and then be clear about the expectation going forward.

- ▶ *Situation:* When and where this has been happening — specific, not general

- ▶ *Behavior*: Exactly what you observed, described factually rather than with a label like "unprofessional" or "lazy"
- ▶ *Impact*: What effect it's actually having — on customers, on the team, on the numbers
- ▶ *Expectation*: What needs to change, specifically, and what happens if it doesn't

This structure works because it keeps the conversation anchored to facts the employee can't easily argue with, rather than character judgments that invite defensiveness.

PART 4

HAVING THE CONVERSATION DIRECTLY

WEAK: *"So, um, I just wanted to check in — how do you feel things have been going lately? Any... challenges?"* — vague enough that the employee can easily deflect, and the actual issue never gets named.

STRONG: *"I want to talk about something specific. Over the last two weeks, I've noticed three separate times where a customer walked away and you didn't offer a Passport handoff to the next department — I saw it Tuesday with the Triumph rider, and again twice on Saturday. That's a real gap from where we need to be, and I want to understand what's going on and get it fixed. Walk me through what's happening in those moments."*

The strong version doesn't soften the issue into vagueness, but it also isn't harsh — it's specific, factual, and opens the door for the employee's side of the story before jumping to conclusions. Directness and respect aren't opposites; the strongest version of this conversation has both.

- ▶ Say the actual issue in the first thirty seconds — don't make the employee guess what the meeting is really about
- ▶ State the impact honestly, without exaggerating it for effect
- ▶ End with a clear, specific expectation and a timeframe, not just a general sense that things need to improve

PART 5

HANDLING EMOTIONAL REACTIONS IN THE ROOM

Some employees will take hard feedback calmly. Others will get defensive, upset, or emotional — and that reaction, on its own, doesn't mean you did something wrong or that the conversation shouldn't have happened.

- ▶ If someone gets defensive, resist the urge to match their energy. Stay calm and restate the facts rather than escalating
- ▶ If someone becomes emotional, it's fine to pause and let them collect themselves — the conversation doesn't have to be rushed to feel complete
- ▶ Don't abandon the conversation just because it got uncomfortable. Finish it, even if you need to soften the pace, rather than letting discomfort cut it short and leaving the issue unresolved

Your own state management from Module 5 matters enormously here. A manager who stays steady while an employee reacts emotionally keeps the conversation productive. A manager who gets pulled into the same emotional state loses the ability to lead it anywhere useful.

PART 6

FOLLOWING UP AND DOCUMENTING

A hard conversation that isn't followed up on tends to fade, and the behavior often drifts right back to where it started. A conversation that's documented and followed up on tends to stick.

- ▶ Write a brief, factual summary of what was discussed and agreed to, even if it's informal — this protects both you and the employee if the issue comes up again
- ▶ Set a specific check-in point, whether that's a week or a month out, rather than leaving improvement open-ended with no follow-up planned
- ▶ If things improve, say so directly and specifically — closing the loop on a hard conversation with genuine acknowledgment matters as much as opening it did

GOAL OF MODULE 8

Every manager can prepare for and run a direct, specific, well-structured performance conversation, stay steady through an emotional reaction without escalating it, and follow through with documentation and a real check-in rather than letting the issue fade.

MODULE 9 — Scheduling & Staffing Fundamentals

MODULE 08 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what does avoiding a difficult conversation typically cost a manager?
 - A. Only the manager's own time
 - B. It only affects the employee involved, not the wider team
 - C. Nothing, as long as the issue eventually resolves itself
 - D. The respect and effort of the team's strongest performers, who are watching whether the issue gets addressed
2. What are the four parts of the structure described in Part 3 for keeping a hard conversation on track?
 - A. Warning, consequence, probation, termination
 - B. Greeting, complaint, apology, resolution
 - C. Praise, criticize, praise, close
 - D. Situation, behavior, impact, expectation
3. In the STRONG example in Part 4, what makes the opening effective?
 - A. It avoids stating the actual issue until the end of the conversation
 - B. It opens with a compliment before addressing the issue
 - C. It states the specific issue within the first thirty seconds, with concrete examples
 - D. It focuses on the employee's general attitude rather than specific incidents
4. According to Part 5, what should a manager do if an employee becomes defensive during a performance conversation?
 - A. Match their energy to show the seriousness of the issue
 - B. Stay calm and restate the facts rather than escalating
 - C. End the conversation immediately
 - D. Apologize for bringing up the issue
5. According to Part 6, why is documenting and following up on a difficult conversation important?
 - A. It's a legal requirement in every case
 - B. It replaces the need for any future coaching
 - C. It's only necessary if the employee disagreed with the feedback
 - D. Without it, the behavior often drifts back to where it started, and there's no record if the issue recurs

MODULE 09

Scheduling & Staffing Fundamentals

A schedule is the most frequent decision you make about your team, and the one they'll judge your fairness by faster than almost anything else you do.

Nothing touches every employee as directly or as often as the schedule. It determines whether they see their kids on a given weekend, whether they can plan a life outside the dealership, and whether they feel like a real person to their manager or just a slot to be filled. Get scheduling right, and it becomes a quiet source of trust. Get it wrong — or get it wrong unevenly across the team — and it becomes one of the fastest ways to lose people who were otherwise doing fine.

PART 1

SCHEDULING IS A PEOPLE DECISION WEARING A NUMBERS COSTUME

It's easy to treat scheduling as a purely operational puzzle: cover the floor, hit the labor targets, fill the shifts. Underneath that puzzle is a much more personal one — every square on that schedule represents a real person's actual life, and how you handle it says something about whether you see them as a person or as a resource.

- ▶ The business genuinely needs coverage — that's not negotiable, and a schedule that ignores it fails everyone, including customers
- ▶ The team genuinely needs some degree of predictability and fairness — that's not negotiable either
- ▶ Good scheduling isn't choosing between the business's needs and the team's needs. It's refusing to treat either one as automatically more important than the other

PART 2

PREDICTABILITY IS A NEED, NOT A LUXURY

Recall the six underlying needs from Module 4 — certainty shows up nowhere more directly than in scheduling. An employee who never knows their schedule more than a few days out lives in a low-grade state of stress that affects their work, whether or not they ever say so directly.

- ▶ Publish schedules as far in advance as your operation realistically allows, and hold that timeline consistently rather than letting it slip
- ▶ If a schedule has to change on short notice, explain why rather than just posting the change silently — the explanation does most of the work in preserving trust
- ▶ Employees who are frequently high on a need for variety may genuinely welcome occasional last-minute changes that others would find stressful — but don't assume that's true without actually knowing the individual

PART 3

BUILDING A FAIR ROTATION

Nothing erodes trust in a schedule faster than the perception — accurate or not — that certain people always get the good shifts and others always get stuck with the rest. Even when there's a legitimate reason behind it, an unexplained pattern reads as favoritism.

- ▶ Rotate weekends, holidays, and less desirable shifts across the team on a consistent, visible system rather than an ad hoc one

- ▶ If someone genuinely does get more flexibility — due to seniority, a specific arrangement, or a real circumstance — say so openly rather than letting the team guess at the reason and assume the worst
- ▶ Ask your team periodically what actually matters most to them schedule-wise. Preferences vary more than managers often assume, and a five-minute conversation can turn a scheduling conflict into a scheduling win for everyone involved

A SCHEDULE THAT FEELS FAIR, EVEN WHEN IT'S NOT PERFECT, BUILDS FAR MORE TRUST THAN A SCHEDULE THAT'S TECHNICALLY OPTIMAL BUT FEELS ARBITRARY

PART 4

HANDLING A SCHEDULE REQUEST OR COMPLAINT

WEAK: *"I can't do anything about it, that's just how the schedule worked out this week."* — technically an answer, and one that signals the request wasn't actually considered.

STRONG: *"Let me actually look at this before I answer — give me until tomorrow. If I can make it work, I will. If I can't, I'll tell you specifically why, not just that it didn't work out."*

The strong version doesn't guarantee the answer the employee wants — sometimes the honest answer really is no. What it guarantees is that the request was genuinely considered and the reasoning is transparent either way, which matters to people almost as much as the outcome itself.

- ▶ Take every request seriously enough to actually look at it, even when you're fairly sure the answer will be no
- ▶ When the answer is no, explain the actual reason rather than a vague "it just doesn't work"
- ▶ Track patterns in requests over time — a single request is easy to accommodate; the same person asking for the same accommodation every week points to a bigger conversation that needs to happen

PART 5

CROSS-TRAINING AS A SCHEDULING SAFETY NET

A team where only one person can competently run a given task is a team one sick day away from a real problem. Modules 12 through 15 build your fluency across every other department — the same principle applies inside your own department. The more people who can competently cover more than one role, the more scheduling flexibility you have, and the less any single absence threatens to derail the whole shift.

- ▶ Identify the single points of failure in your current schedule — the shifts or tasks only one person can reliably cover
- ▶ Build cross-training into slower periods deliberately, rather than only discovering the gap during a crisis
- ▶ A team member who can competently cover more than their primary role becomes more valuable to the schedule and, often, more engaged in the work itself

PART 6

WHEN YOU'RE GENUINELY SHORT-STAFFED

Every department hits stretches of being short-staffed — a departure, an unexpected leave, a slow hiring process. How a manager handles that stretch says a lot about their leadership under real constraint.

- ▶ Be honest with the team about the situation rather than pretending everything is fine while everyone's clearly stretched thin
- ▶ Watch for burnout signs in the people covering the gap — a short-staffed stretch that goes on too long without acknowledgment risks losing the very people holding it together
- ▶ Resist the instinct to lower the customer experience standard just because the team is stretched — find ways to protect the standard even if it means covering shifts yourself in the short term

GOAL OF MODULE 9

Every manager can build a schedule that balances real business coverage needs with real fairness and predictability for the team, handle requests and complaints transparently, and use cross-training as a genuine safety net rather than discovering staffing gaps only in a crisis.

MODULE 10 — Metrics That Matter: Reading Your Department Dashboard

MODULE 09 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what does this module say good scheduling requires?
 - A. Refusing to treat either the business's needs or the team's needs as automatically more important
 - B. Prioritizing the business's coverage needs above all else
 - C. Prioritizing the team's preferences above all else
 - D. Letting employees set their own schedules entirely
2. Which underlying need from Module 4 does Part 2 say is most directly tied to scheduling?
 - A. Growth
 - B. Certainty
 - C. Significance
 - D. Contribution
3. According to Part 3, what erodes trust in a schedule fastest, even when there's a legitimate reason behind it?
 - A. Publishing the schedule too far in advance
 - B. Rotating weekend shifts across the team
 - C. Asking employees about their scheduling preferences
 - D. An unexplained pattern that reads as favoritism
4. In the WEAK/STRONG example about a schedule request, what does the STRONG version guarantee?
 - A. The schedule will never change again
 - B. The request was genuinely considered, with a transparent reason given either way
 - C. All future requests will be automatically approved
 - D. The employee will always get the answer they want
5. According to Part 5, what is the benefit of cross-training within a manager's own department?
 - A. It only benefits the employee being cross-trained, not the schedule itself
 - B. It eliminates the need for a written schedule
 - C. It replaces the need for hiring additional staff
 - D. It reduces single points of failure and increases scheduling flexibility

MODULE 10

Metrics That Matter: Reading Your Department Dashboard

A manager who only looks at the numbers once a month isn't managing the department — they're getting a monthly report card on decisions they already made weeks ago, with no chance to change the outcome.

Every department at Motos America runs on numbers — some department-specific, some universal. The manager who checks those numbers only when corporate asks for them is always working from stale information, reacting to problems that are already fully formed instead of catching them while they're still small. The manager who reads their dashboard regularly, and actually understands what it's telling them, gets to make decisions while there's still time for those decisions to matter.

PART 1

WHY THE DASHBOARD MATTERS MORE THAN THE MONTHLY REPORT

A monthly summary tells you what already happened. It's useful for understanding the past, but by the time it lands in your inbox, the month that produced it is over — there's nothing left to do about it except try to do better next time. A dashboard checked regularly throughout the month gives you something a monthly report never can: time to actually change the outcome while the month is still being written.

- ▶ Waiting for the monthly report to learn about a problem means you're always at least a few weeks behind it
- ▶ Checking your numbers weekly, or even more often during a tight month, turns metrics into a tool for decisions instead of just a scorecard
- ▶ The goal isn't to obsess over the dashboard constantly — it's to check it often enough that nothing genuinely surprises you at month's end

A MANAGER WHO'S SURPRISED BY THE MONTHLY REPORT WASN'T PAYING ATTENTION TO THE WEEKS THAT PRODUCED IT

PART 2

LEADING INDICATORS VERSUS LAGGING INDICATORS

Every set of metrics contains two different kinds of numbers, and confusing them is one of the most common mistakes new managers make. Lagging indicators tell you what already happened — monthly revenue, closed deals, completed repair orders. Leading indicators tell you what's likely to happen next, if a trend continues — daily traffic, conversion rates, appointment show rates, the pace of activity happening right now.

- ▶ Lagging indicators are what gets reported upward — they matter, but by the time you see them, the window to influence them has already closed
- ▶ Leading indicators are what a manager should actually be watching day to day — they're the early warning system that gives you time to actually act
- ▶ A department that's missing its lagging numbers at month's end almost always showed warning signs in its leading indicators weeks earlier — the question is whether anyone was watching closely enough to notice

PART 3

KNOWING WHICH NUMBERS ARE ACTUALLY YOURS TO WATCH

Every department dashboard is different in its specifics, but the categories a manager needs fluency in look similar across Sales, Service, Parts, and F&I: activity and volume, conversion and close rate, customer satisfaction, and efficiency or throughput. Know which specific numbers in your own department's dashboard map to each category, and check all four regularly — not just the one that's easiest to look at or feels most comfortable.

- ▶ It's tempting to focus only on the number you're most confident about and quietly avoid the one that makes you uncomfortable — resist that instinct deliberately
- ▶ Customer satisfaction numbers deserve the same regular attention as revenue numbers, even though they can feel softer or harder to act on directly
- ▶ If you genuinely don't know what a number on your dashboard represents or how it's calculated, find out — guessing at what a metric means leads to guessing at how to fix it

PART 4

READING A TREND VERSUS REACTING TO A SINGLE DATA POINT

One bad day, one slow week, one unusually low number doesn't automatically mean something is broken — it might just be normal variation. Reacting hard to every single data point creates a team that's anxious about noise instead of focused on signal. The skill is learning to tell the difference.

- ▶ A single off day is rarely worth a team-wide reaction — investigate quietly first, before making it a bigger conversation than it needs to be
- ▶ Three or more consecutive data points moving in the same direction is a real trend worth addressing directly, not just monitoring
- ▶ Context matters — a slow week during a known seasonal dip means something very different than an unexplained slow week during a typically strong period

PART 5

TALKING TO YOUR TEAM ABOUT A DECLINING NUMBER

WEAK: *"Our numbers are down and that's not okay. We need to turn this around, starting now."* — true, vague, and gives the team nothing actionable to actually change.

STRONG: *"I want to walk through something with you all. Our conversion rate has dropped for three weeks running — here's exactly where I think it's happening [specific data], and here's what I want us to try this week. I want your read on this too — does this match what you're seeing on the floor?"*

The strong version treats the team as partners in solving the problem, not as the source of it. It's specific about where the issue actually is, invites their perspective, and gives a concrete next step — all of which the weak version skips entirely.

- ▶ Lead with the data, not with blame — a declining number has causes, and finding them matters more than assigning fault
- ▶ Ask the team what they're seeing before announcing your own theory — they're often closer to the real cause than the dashboard alone reveals
- ▶ Close with something specific to try, not just a general call to "do better"

PART 6

TURNING NUMBERS INTO COACHING, NOT JUST REPORTING

The real value of a dashboard isn't the number itself — it's what the number tells you about where to coach next. A manager who simply reports the numbers upward and downward, without connecting them to specific coaching, is only doing half the job.

- ▶ If one team member's numbers consistently trail the rest, that's a coaching conversation per Module 7, not just a data point to note
- ▶ If the whole team's numbers move together, the cause is more likely something systemic — training, a process gap, a market shift — than an individual performance issue
- ▶ Numbers tell you *where* to look. Coaching conversations tell you *why* — and only the second one actually fixes anything

GOAL OF MODULE 10

Every manager reads their dashboard regularly rather than waiting for the monthly report, distinguishes leading indicators from lagging ones, knows which numbers across all four key categories are theirs to watch, and connects trends to specific coaching rather than treating numbers as an end in themselves.

MODULE 11 — Budgets, P&L Basics & Cost Control

MODULE 10 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what is the main limitation of relying only on the monthly report?
 - A. Monthly reports don't include customer satisfaction data
 - B. By the time it arrives, the month that produced it is already over, leaving no time to change the outcome
 - C. Monthly reports are usually inaccurate
 - D. Monthly reports are only available to General Managers
2. What is the difference between a leading indicator and a lagging indicator, according to Part 2?
 - A. There is no meaningful difference between the two
 - B. Lagging indicators show what already happened; leading indicators signal what's likely to happen next
 - C. Lagging indicators are specific to Sales, and leading indicators are specific to Service
 - D. Leading indicators are always more accurate than lagging indicators
3. According to Part 3, what instinct should a manager resist when reviewing their dashboard?
 - A. Reviewing the dashboard more than once a month
 - B. Checking customer satisfaction numbers at all
 - C. Asking what a metric means if they don't understand it
 - D. Focusing only on the number they're most comfortable with and avoiding the uncomfortable one
4. According to Part 4, when is a data point considered a real trend worth addressing directly?
 - A. Three or more consecutive data points moving in the same direction
 - B. Only during the final week of the month
 - C. Only if corporate flags it first
 - D. Any single off day
5. In the STRONG example in Part 5, what does the manager do differently than in the WEAK version?
 - A. Assigns blame to a specific team member
 - B. Shares specific data, invites the team's perspective, and proposes a concrete next step
 - C. Avoids mentioning the numbers directly
 - D. Announces a policy change without team input

MODULE 11

Budgets, P&L Basics & Cost Control

You don't need to be an accountant to run a department well. You do need to understand where your department's money actually goes — because every decision you make either protects it or quietly drains it.

Many managers reach this role having mastered the craft of their department — selling, servicing, fitting, financing — without ever being taught how that craft connects to the dealership's actual profitability. That gap is worth closing early. Understanding the basic financial picture of your department doesn't make you a bean counter. It makes you a manager who understands the real consequences of the decisions you're already making every day.

PART 1

WHY THIS MATTERS EVEN IF NUMBERS AREN'T YOUR STRENGTH

Every decision a manager makes has a financial shadow, whether or not the manager is thinking about it in those terms — a schedule built with too much overtime, a discount given too easily, a return handled generously without checking the cost. None of these decisions are automatically wrong. But a manager who understands the financial picture makes those calls with real information instead of guessing.

- ▶ You don't need to master accounting — you need enough fluency to understand what your decisions actually cost and produce
- ▶ Financial literacy isn't optional at this level, even for managers who came up purely on people skills or technical craft
- ▶ A manager who understands their numbers can defend a smart decision to their GM with real confidence, instead of a shrug

PART 2

THE BASICS, IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Strip away the jargon, and every department's financial picture comes down to a few simple ideas stacked on top of each other.

- ▶ *Revenue* is everything that comes in — what customers pay for parts, labor, the motorcycle itself, the products sold
- ▶ *Cost of goods* is what it actually cost the dealership to provide what was sold — the wholesale cost of a part, the cost of the motorcycle itself before it's marked up
- ▶ *Gross profit* is revenue minus cost of goods — what's left before the department's own operating expenses are subtracted
- ▶ *Operating expenses* are what it costs to run the department day to day — labor, supplies, the everyday cost of doing business
- ▶ *Net* is what's actually left once everything is accounted for — the true bottom-line result of the department's performance

Every department manager doesn't need to build this statement from scratch. Every department manager does need to be able to read one and understand, roughly, what each line is telling them.

PART 3

THE LEVERS THAT ARE ACTUALLY YOURS TO PULL

Not every line on a P&L is within a department manager's control — some costs are set well above the department level. Focus your attention on the levers that genuinely are yours to influence, rather than spending energy worrying about numbers you can't actually move.

- ▶ *Labor cost.* Scheduling efficiently, controlling unnecessary overtime, and matching staffing to actual demand are almost entirely within a manager's control
- ▶ *Waste and shrinkage.* Careless handling of inventory, unnecessary comebacks, and avoidable errors all cost real money that traces directly back to day-to-day management
- ▶ *Discretionary discounting.* How freely discounts, comps, or exceptions are given is usually a manager-level decision, and it adds up faster than it feels like it does in any single instance
- ▶ *Efficiency.* How well the team's time is actually used — versus standing around, duplicated effort, or poor workflow — shows up directly in the numbers over time

PART 4

PROTECTING THE STANDARD WHILE PROTECTING THE BUDGET

Cost control and the Motos America standard from Module 3 are not opposites, even though it can feel that way under pressure. The mistake to avoid is treating cost-cutting as an excuse to quietly lower the customer experience — cutting a corner that damages trust to save a small amount of money is rarely actually a good trade, even purely in financial terms.

- ▶ Look for waste and inefficiency first — those cuts rarely touch the customer experience at all
- ▶ Be skeptical of any cost-saving idea that requires visibly reducing what the customer experiences — the long-term cost of that erosion is usually larger than the short-term savings
- ▶ A department that hits its numbers by quietly cutting the standard is setting up a much bigger problem for whoever manages it next — including, eventually, a future version of you

A DOLLAR SAVED BY DAMAGING THE CUSTOMER EXPERIENCE IS RARELY ACTUALLY A DOLLAR SAVED

PART 5

EXPLAINING A BUDGET CONSTRAINT TO YOUR TEAM

WEAK: *"We can't do that, it's not in the budget."* — technically true, and completely unhelpful in explaining why, which makes it sound arbitrary even when it isn't.

STRONG: *"I hear you on that — here's honestly where we stand: we've got room to make this work if we can find it elsewhere, but not as an add-on to what we're already spending. Let's look at what we could shift to make it happen, or figure out timing that works better."*

The strong version treats a budget limit as a real constraint to problem-solve around together, not a wall to hide behind. It doesn't promise something that isn't realistic, but it also doesn't shut the conversation down without genuinely engaging with the request.

- ▶ Explain the actual constraint honestly rather than hiding behind "budget" as an unexplained wall
- ▶ Where possible, offer an alternative or a timeline rather than a flat no
- ▶ Being transparent about real financial limits, within reason, tends to build more trust than pretending the department has unlimited flexibility

PART 6

READING YOUR NUMBERS ALONGSIDE YOUR GM

Your General Manager sees the dealership-wide financial picture in ways you don't, and your department numbers are one piece of a much larger puzzle they're managing. Come to conversations with your GM about budget and performance prepared, not just reactive.

- ▶ Know your own numbers well enough to walk into a GM conversation with answers, not just questions
- ▶ If a number is off, be ready to explain what you think is driving it and what you're already doing about it — not just report the number itself
- ▶ Treat your GM as a resource for understanding the bigger financial picture, the same way your team should be treating you — this relationship gets covered in real depth starting in Module 16

GOAL OF MODULE 11

Every manager has basic fluency in how their department's revenue, costs, and profit connect, knows which financial levers are genuinely within their control, and understands that protecting the customer standard and protecting the budget are almost always aligned rather than in conflict.

MODULE 12 — Cross-Training Spotlight: Sales

MODULE 11 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, why does this module say financial literacy matters even for managers who came up on people skills or technical craft?

- A. It's a formal requirement for promotion regardless of role**
- B. Every decision a manager makes has a financial shadow, and understanding it means making decisions with real information instead of guessing**
- C. Managers are expected to personally prepare the dealership's financial statements**
- D. It replaces the need for coaching or people skills entirely**

2. According to Part 2, what is gross profit?

- A. Revenue minus operating expenses only**
- B. The department's total labor cost**
- C. Total revenue with no deductions**
- D. Revenue minus cost of goods**

3. Which of the following is described in Part 3 as a lever genuinely within a department manager's control?

- A. The dealership's overall marketing budget**
- B. Corporate overhead allocation**
- C. Manufacturer wholesale pricing**
- D. Labor cost through efficient scheduling**

4. According to Part 4, what mistake does this module warn managers against when trying to control costs?

- A. Looking for waste and inefficiency before cutting anything else**
- B. Discussing budget constraints with the team at all**
- C. Cutting corners that damage the customer experience to achieve small savings**
- D. Being skeptical of cost-saving ideas**

5. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 5, what does the STRONG version do differently?

- A. It approves every request regardless of budget**
- B. It avoids discussing the budget at all**
- C. It blames corporate for the limitation**
- D. It treats the budget constraint as a real problem to solve together, rather than an unexplained wall**

MODULE 12

Cross-Training Spotlight: Sales

You don't need to be able to close a deal. You do need to understand what a good one actually looks like — because your team, your customers, and your own department's reputation are all connected to how well Sales does its job.

This module, and the three that follow it, assume you've already read the academy for your own department. What they add is fluency in the other departments you don't personally run — enough real understanding to speak intelligently in a cross-department conversation, recognize when something's genuinely off, and step in competently if you're ever called on to. This isn't about becoming a Sales expert. It's about never being the manager standing in a room with nothing useful to contribute when Sales comes up.

PART 1

WHY SALES FLUENCY MATTERS EVEN IF YOU DON'T RUN THE FLOOR

Every customer's relationship with Motos America usually starts in Sales, whether or not they ever set foot in your department. How that first experience goes shapes what they expect from every department that follows — including yours. A rushed, pressure-heavy sales experience produces a skeptical customer everywhere else in the building. A trust-based one sets every downstream department up to succeed.

- ▶ Whatever Sales promises, your department eventually has to help deliver on
- ▶ A customer's trust — or distrust — in the dealership as a whole is heavily shaped by how their sales experience went, long before they ever reach your department
- ▶ Understanding Sales well enough to reinforce its standard, rather than quietly undermining it out of unfamiliarity, protects the whole customer relationship

PART 2

TRUSTED RIDING CONSULTANT, NOT TRADITIONAL SALESPERSON

Sales Academy trains people to be trusted riding consultants, not traditional salespeople — a real philosophical difference, not just softer language for the same job. A traditional salesperson's goal is closing the deal in front of them. A trusted riding consultant's goal is helping a customer make the right decision for their riding life, which usually produces the sale as a natural byproduct rather than the objective being chased directly.

- ▶ Sales Professionals are trained to educate before they sell — knowledge builds trust, and trust is what actually produces sales, not pressure
- ▶ The best Sales interactions feel like genuine guidance, not a pitch — that's a deliberate outcome of training, not an accident
- ▶ Any pressure-heavy, transaction-focused behavior you see from a Sales team member is a real deviation from the standard they were trained on, worth naming if you notice it

PART 3

THE CORE SALES PROCESS, AT A GLANCE

You don't need to run this process yourself, but recognizing its shape helps you understand what a Sales Professional is actually doing at each stage, and where things tend to go wrong when they do.

- ▶ *Discovery and needs analysis.* Understanding who the customer actually is as a rider — experience level, intended use, real budget — before recommending anything
- ▶ *Product presentation and demonstration.* Matching what's shown to what discovery actually revealed, not just showing whatever's easiest to sell that day
- ▶ *Test rides.* A genuine part of helping a customer make a confident decision, not a formality to rush through
- ▶ *Negotiation and closing.* Guiding a customer to a decision they feel good about, not pressuring them into one they'll regret
- ▶ *Follow-up and referral generation.* The relationship continuing well past the signature — the foundation of the "riders for life" philosophy every academy shares

PART 4

WHAT TO WATCH FOR AS AN OUTSIDE MANAGER

You're not expected to coach a Sales Professional's technique — that's the Sales Manager's job. You are in a position to notice patterns worth flagging, especially if you're covering the floor or simply present when something looks off.

- ▶ A customer who seems rushed, confused, or pressured is worth a quiet check-in, even if it's not your department
- ▶ Genuine enthusiasm and product knowledge look very different from a rehearsed script — you'll learn to spot the difference with exposure
- ▶ If you notice something concerning, raise it directly and respectfully with the Sales Manager rather than addressing their team member yourself — respecting department boundaries matters as much as raising the concern at all

PART 5

SALES' ROLE IN LAUNCHING THE PASSPORT HANDOFF

Every customer's Passport journey begins in Sales, at the point of purchase. How that first handoff happens sets the tone for every department that follows — Parts, Service, F&I, and eventually back to Sales again for the next motorcycle down the road.

- ▶ A strong Sales-to-next-department handoff introduces the customer by name to a real person, not just a location or department name
- ▶ A weak handoff — "Parts is over there" — is the exact gap Module 3 covers, and it's just as real a risk in Sales as anywhere else
- ▶ As a manager in any department, reinforcing the importance of a strong Passport handoff coming out of Sales protects the customer experience your own department eventually inherits

PART 6

STEPPING IN WITHOUT OVERSTEPPING

WEAK: *(covering the floor during a Sales Manager's day off, a customer asks a detailed financing question) "I don't really know Sales stuff, you'll have to wait for someone else."* — leaves the customer without help and reflects poorly on the whole dealership.

STRONG: *"That's a great question — I want to make sure you get the exact right answer rather than a guess from me. Let me grab someone who handles this every day so you get it right the first time."*

The strong version doesn't pretend to have expertise you don't have, but it also doesn't leave the customer stranded. Knowing the boundary of your own competence — and handing off smoothly when you hit it — is itself a form of cross-department fluency.

- ▶ It's fine, even expected, to say "that's outside what I know well" — what matters is what you do next
- ▶ Never fake expertise you don't have to avoid an awkward moment — a wrong answer does more damage than an honest handoff
- ▶ Genuine familiarity with the Sales process, built through this module and real exposure over time, means you can cover competently far more often than you might expect

GOAL OF MODULE 12

Every manager understands the trusted-riding-consultant philosophy behind Sales, recognizes the shape of the core sales process well enough to notice when something's off, understands Sales' role in launching the Passport journey, and can competently cover or support the Sales floor without overstepping into territory outside their expertise.

MODULE 13 — Cross-Training Spotlight: Service

MODULE 12 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

- 1. According to Part 1, why does Sales fluency matter for managers outside the Sales department?**
 - A. A customer's trust in the entire dealership is heavily shaped by their sales experience, before they ever reach other departments**
 - B. Sales performance has no real effect on other departments**
 - C. Sales Managers report directly to every other department manager**
 - D. Every manager is required to sell motorcycles occasionally**

- 2. According to Part 2, what is the key difference between a "trusted riding consultant" and a "traditional salesperson"?**
 - A. A trusted riding consultant doesn't participate in negotiation or closing**
 - B. There is no real difference, just different language**
 - C. A trusted riding consultant focuses on the customer's right decision, which produces the sale as a byproduct, rather than chasing the close directly**
 - D. A traditional salesperson only sells used motorcycles**

- 3. According to Part 4, what should a manager do if they notice a Sales team member's behavior seems concerning?**
 - A. Address the team member directly themselves**
 - B. Raise it directly and respectfully with the Sales Manager**
 - C. Report it to the customer immediately**
 - D. Ignore it, since it's outside their department**

- 4. According to Part 5, where does a customer's Passport journey begin?**
 - A. In the Parts & Accessories department**
 - B. In Service, at the first maintenance visit**
 - C. In F&I, during financing**
 - D. In Sales, at the point of purchase**

- 5. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 6, what does the STRONG response demonstrate?**
 - A. Faking expertise to avoid an awkward moment**
 - B. Directing the customer to look up the answer themselves**
 - C. Refusing to engage with the customer's question at all**
 - D. Recognizing the limit of one's own knowledge and handing off smoothly rather than leaving the customer stranded**

MODULE 13

Cross-Training Spotlight: Service

Sales sells the dream once. Service keeps that promise running for years — and how well your dealership does that is the single biggest factor in whether a customer ever buys from you again.

Service is the department most customers interact with more than any other, year after year, long after the initial sale is a memory. A manager who doesn't understand how the Service department actually operates is missing fluency in the part of the business most responsible for turning a one-time buyer into a lifetime customer.

PART 1

WHY SERVICE FLUENCY MATTERS EVEN IF YOU DON'T RUN THE SHOP

Every academy shares the belief that success isn't measured by today's sale — it's measured by whether customers keep coming back. Service is where that promise gets tested, repeatedly, over the entire life of the customer's relationship with the dealership. A strong Service experience quietly reinforces every other department's work. A weak one can undo it.

- ▶ A customer who trusts Service tends to trust the whole dealership, and vice versa
- ▶ Service touches the same customer many more times than a single sales transaction ever does — its impact compounds over years
- ▶ Whatever confidence Sales built during the purchase either gets reinforced or eroded at the customer's very first service visit

PART 2

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE CONSULTANT, NOT ORDER-TAKER

Service Advisor Academy trains Service Advisors to be professional service consultants — people who educate customers about their motorcycle's needs and guide real decisions, not people who simply write down a repair request and hand over a bill. The difference shows up constantly in how service visits actually feel to a customer.

- ▶ An order-taker asks what's wrong and writes it down. A consultant inspects, explains, and educates before ever presenting a recommendation
- ▶ Presenting an estimate well is a skill in itself — the goal is a customer who understands and trusts the recommendation, not one who simply accepts or rejects a number
- ▶ A Service Advisor who handles objections by explaining rather than pressuring is doing exactly what the academy trains — worth recognizing and reinforcing when you see it

PART 3

THE CORE SERVICE PROCESS, AT A GLANCE

- ▶ *Customer communication and check-in.* Setting the tone for the whole visit — a rushed or transactional check-in colors everything that follows
- ▶ *Inspection.* A genuine, thorough look at the motorcycle, not a cursory glance — this is where real problems, and real opportunities to help the customer, actually get found
- ▶ *Maintenance education.* Helping the customer understand what their bike actually needs and why, in plain language, rather than assuming they already know

- ▶ *Presenting the estimate.* Framed around value and safety, not simply a price to accept or decline
- ▶ *Objection handling.* Addressing real hesitation with real explanation, never with pressure
- ▶ *Customer retention.* The entire process aimed at the customer choosing to come back next time, not just completing this one visit

PART 4

WHAT TO WATCH FOR AS AN OUTSIDE MANAGER

- ▶ A customer who leaves confused about what was actually done to their motorcycle, or why, is a sign the education step got skipped
- ▶ An advisor who seems to be rushing through check-ins on a busy day is worth a quiet, supportive check-in — busy days are exactly when the standard is most tempting to cut
- ▶ As with Sales, if you notice something concerning in how a Service interaction is handled, raise it with the Service Manager directly rather than intervening with their team member yourself

PART 5

SERVICE'S ROLE IN SUSTAINING THE PASSPORT EXPERIENCE

If Sales launches the Passport journey, Service is often where it's sustained or quietly allowed to fade. A customer's first service visit, months after the sale, is a real test of whether the relationship Sales built was genuine or just part of the transaction.

- ▶ A strong Service handoff back to Parts for an accessory need, or forward to the next visit, keeps the Passport thread alive well past the original purchase
- ▶ A Service department that treats each visit as a standalone transaction, disconnected from the customer's full relationship with the dealership, lets the Passport thread quietly go slack
- ▶ Service Advisors who remember details from a customer's history — their riding style, past concerns, even personal details mentioned in passing — reinforce that the dealership sees them as a relationship, not a repeat transaction

PART 6

STEPPING IN WITHOUT OVERSTEPPING

WEAK: *(covering the Service desk during a staffing gap, a customer asks a detailed question about a repair's technical cause) "I'm not sure, it's probably fine though."* — guesses rather than admitting the limit of their knowledge, and risks giving inaccurate information.

STRONG: *"That's a great question, and I want you to get an accurate answer rather than my best guess — let me get one of our advisors or technicians to walk you through exactly what's going on."*

The strong version protects both the customer's trust and the department's credibility. A confident-sounding wrong answer does far more damage than an honest, quick handoff to someone who actually knows.

- ▶ Familiarity with the Service process, built through this module, lets you cover competently for scheduling, check-ins, and general customer questions
- ▶ Technical diagnosis and repair recommendations should always go to a trained Service Advisor or Technician — that boundary exists for good reason and should be respected even under staffing pressure
- ▶ A manager who's genuinely fluent in Service, without pretending to be a Service Advisor, is exactly the kind of cross-department strength this manual is building

GOAL OF MODULE 13

Every manager understands the professional-service-consultant philosophy behind Service Advisor Academy, recognizes the shape of the core service process, understands Service's role in sustaining the Passport relationship over time, and can competently support the Service desk without overstepping into technical territory outside their expertise.

MODULE 14 — Cross-Training Spotlight: Parts & Accessories

MODULE 13 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

- 1. According to Part 1, why does Service have an outsized impact on whether a customer returns to the dealership?**
 - A. Service touches the same customer repeatedly over years, testing the relationship far more than a single sales transaction
 - B. Service is the only department customers interact with after the sale
 - C. Service generates more revenue than any other department
 - D. Service is required to contact every customer monthly
- 2. According to Part 2, what is the key difference between an "order-taker" and a "professional service consultant"?**
 - A. A consultant inspects, explains, and educates before presenting a recommendation, rather than simply writing down a request
 - B. A consultant never discusses pricing with the customer
 - C. There is no meaningful difference between the two roles
 - D. An order-taker completes repairs faster
- 3. According to Part 4, what is a sign that the maintenance education step of a service visit was skipped?**
 - A. The customer leaves confused about what was actually done to their motorcycle and why
 - B. The customer asks no questions during check-in
 - C. The estimate was presented in writing
 - D. The visit took less time than expected
- 4. According to Part 5, what happens when Service treats each visit as a standalone transaction disconnected from the customer's full relationship?**
 - A. It improves efficiency without any tradeoff
 - B. The Passport thread that Sales launched is allowed to quietly go slack
 - C. It has no effect on the Passport experience
 - D. It only affects the Parts department, not Service
- 5. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 6, why does the STRONG response avoid guessing at a technical answer?**
 - A. Guessing is faster than finding the right person
 - B. Customers prefer not to receive technical explanations at all
 - C. Technical questions are outside the scope of any Motos America employee
 - D. A confident-sounding wrong answer damages trust more than an honest handoff to someone who knows

MODULE 14

Cross-Training Spotlight: Parts & Accessories

Parts sees nearly every customer, nearly every visit, whether they're buying a bike, fixing one, or just making the one they have feel more like theirs — which means how your team talks about that department shapes a huge share of the customer's overall relationship with the dealership.

Parts & Accessories is the department most likely to be underestimated by managers who don't run it — easy to think of as a simple counter operation rather than the relationship-sustaining, revenue-driving department it actually is. Real fluency here changes that perception fast.

PART 1

WHY PARTS FLUENCY MATTERS EVEN IF YOU DON'T RUN THE COUNTER

Parts touches nearly every customer relationship at some point — the rider getting an oil change, the customer personalizing a new purchase, the technician who needs a part right now to keep a repair order moving. Understanding how that department actually operates gives you a much fuller picture of how the whole dealership connects.

- ▶ Every part sold over the counter, an online retailer would happily sell instead — the experience is the entire differentiator, which makes how the department is run a real strategic concern, not a minor operational one
- ▶ Parts sees the same customer for years after the sale — oil changes, tires, a farkle finally installed, the eventual upgrade — making it one of the biggest drivers of the "riders for life" philosophy every academy shares
- ▶ A weak Parts experience can quietly undo a strong Sales and Service experience, and a great one can help repair a relationship that started rocky elsewhere

PART 2

SOLUTION SELLING, NOT ORDER FULFILLMENT

Parts & Accessories Academy trains associates in solution selling — helping a customer personalize and enjoy their motorcycle, not simply filling whatever order comes across the counter. The difference shows up in whether a visit feels like genuine help or a transaction.

- ▶ A solution-selling mindset asks what the rider is actually trying to accomplish, not just what part number they walked in asking for
- ▶ Riding gear, apparel, and accessories are treated as part of the rider's identity and experience, not just add-on merchandise to upsell
- ▶ Seasonal opportunities and package building are approached as genuine value for the customer, not simply a sales tactic

PART 3

THREE JOBS INSIDE ONE ROLE

Parts & Accessories covers three distinct conversations, often within the same hour, and understanding this structure is the fastest way to make sense of what looks, from the outside, like a chaotic environment.

- ▶ *The front counter* — a rider walks in needing a part, an answer, or just some guidance

- ▶ *The rear counter* — a technician needs a part right now to keep a repair order moving, and treating that tech as an internal customer whose time equals dealership revenue is a real, trained standard, not an afterthought
- ▶ *Accessories and apparel* — helping a rider's bike, and the rider themselves, look and perform the way they imagined when they bought it

PART 4

WHAT TO WATCH FOR AS AN OUTSIDE MANAGER

- ▶ A rear counter that consistently makes technicians wait is a red flag worth raising — it slows the entire shop, not just Parts, and the cost shows up in Service's numbers as much as Parts'
- ▶ An associate who reflexively reaches for the cheaper option without asking what the customer is actually trying to accomplish is missing the solution-selling standard
- ▶ As with Sales and Service, raise concerns with the Parts Manager directly rather than coaching their team member yourself

PART 5

PARTS' ROLE IN THE PASSPORT JOURNEY

Parts is often where the Passport relationship becomes tangible — the place a customer comes back to again and again long after the original purchase, making every visit a chance to either deepen the relationship or quietly damage it.

- ▶ A strong Parts handoff — to Service for a related need, or simply a warm, personal interaction — reinforces that the dealership is one connected team, not a series of separate transactions
- ▶ Because Parts sees repeat customers so frequently, it's uniquely positioned to notice when a customer's broader relationship with the dealership seems to be fading, and to flag that back through Passport
- ▶ A customer who feels genuinely helped at the parts counter tells other riders — Passport's ripple effect is especially visible in this department

PART 6

STEPPING IN WITHOUT OVERSTEPPING

WEAK: *(covering the counter during a staffing gap, a tech asks for a part mid-repair) "I'll get to it when I can, I've got customers."* — treats the tech's need as lower priority, when in this department it's a customer relationship in its own right.

STRONG: *"Give me two minutes with this customer and I'll come straight to you — you're not waiting behind anyone, I promise."*

The strong version reflects the trained standard that a waiting technician is an internal customer, not an interruption. Treating that relationship with the same urgency as a walk-in customer is one of the fastest ways to earn real credibility with a Parts team while covering their department.

- ▶ Real fluency in Parts means understanding the rear counter is not a lower priority than the front counter — it's a different customer, with the same standard of care
- ▶ Familiarity with basic solution-selling questions lets you cover front-counter conversations competently, even without deep product knowledge
- ▶ Specific product and fitment questions should always go to a trained Parts associate — that boundary protects the customer from inaccurate information as much as any technical boundary in Service does

GOAL OF MODULE 14

Every manager understands the solution-selling philosophy behind Parts & Accessories Academy, recognizes the three distinct conversations that make up the role, understands Parts' outsized role in sustaining the Passport relationship over years of repeat visits, and can competently support the counter without overstepping into product expertise outside their training.

PART I EXAM — Modules 1–14

MODULE 14 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

- 1. According to this module, what is the core idea behind "solution selling" in Parts & Accessories?**
 - A. Focusing exclusively on apparel and accessories rather than parts
 - B. Always steering the customer toward the most expensive available option
 - C. Filling every order exactly as requested, without asking further questions
 - D. Asking what the rider is actually trying to accomplish, not just filling the part number requested

- 2. According to Part 3, what are the three distinct conversations that make up the Parts & Accessories role?**
 - A. Retail, wholesale, and warranty
 - B. Sales, Service, and F&I
 - C. Front counter, rear counter, and accessories/apparel
 - D. Inventory, ordering, and returns

- 3. According to Part 4, what is a red flag worth raising if a manager notices it at the rear counter?**
 - A. The rear counter consistently making technicians wait
 - B. Technicians being treated with the same urgency as front-counter customers
 - C. Associates asking customers clarifying questions
 - D. A slow period with no customers at the front counter

- 4. According to Part 5, why is Parts uniquely positioned within the Passport journey?**
 - A. It has no real connection to the Passport process
 - B. It is the only department that interacts with a customer more than once
 - C. It is responsible for closing every Passport handoff dealership-wide
 - D. It sees repeat customers frequently, making it well positioned to notice when a broader relationship seems to be fading

- 5. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 6, what standard does the STRONG response reflect?**
 - A. Customers should always be prioritized over waiting technicians
 - B. A waiting technician is treated as an internal customer, with the same urgency as a walk-in
 - C. Technicians should place orders in advance to avoid waiting
 - D. Associates should avoid promising a specific timeframe to anyone

PART I EXAM

Leading the Department

20 questions covering everything in Part I. Circle your answers, then check the key at the end.

1. According to Module 1, what does Management Academy assume the reader has already completed or is deeply familiar with?

- A. Their own department's academy**
- B. Passport Academy only**
- C. A four-year business degree**
- D. Executive Academy**

2. According to Module 1, what are the three things Management Academy builds in every manager?

- A. Vendor relationships, inventory control, and marketing**
- B. Sales technique, financial modeling, and public speaking**
- C. Hiring, firing, and scheduling**
- D. People leadership, operational management, and culture and standard**

3. According to Module 2, what is the difference between authority and respect?

- A. Respect is granted with the title; authority must be earned**
- B. Neither can change once a manager is promoted**
- C. Authority is granted with the title; respect must be earned through behavior**
- D. They mean the same thing in a management context**

4. According to Module 2, what is the most common mistake new managers make in their first ninety days?

- A. Asking other managers for help too soon**
- B. Arriving with a list of changes before understanding why things are the way they are**
- C. Meeting individually with every team member**
- D. Establishing a consistent one-on-one rhythm**

5. According to Module 3, what actually determines a department's culture?

- A. The department's location within the dealership**
- B. How long the manager has held the role**
- C. The mission statement on the wall**
- D. What the manager tolerates and enforces, not what they state**

6. According to Module 3, what is a manager's ongoing responsibility regarding Passport?

- A. Reporting Passport compliance to corporate monthly**
- B. None — it's fully covered during initial employee training**
- C. Actively watching for erosion in handoffs and coaching it back into shape**
- D. Personally handling every customer handoff**

7. According to Module 4, which of the following is one of the six underlying needs that drive behavior?

- A. Location**
- B. Compensation**
- C. Certainty**

D. Seniority

8. According to Module 4, what is the correct use of the six-needs framework?

- A. To determine starting pay for new hires**
- B. To understand and coach people more effectively, without lowering the standard**
- C. To excuse poor performance once its cause is identified**
- D. To replace formal performance reviews entirely**

9. According to Module 5, what is the only factual part of a difficult moment, according to the "what happened, story, strategy" framework?

- A. The manager's emotional reaction**
- B. What actually happened, before interpretation is added**
- C. The story told about what it means**
- D. The strategy chosen in response**

10. According to Module 6, what should a manager weigh more heavily than experience when evaluating a candidate above the role's basic skill floor?

- A. Years of prior industry experience**
- B. Character, coachability, and honesty**
- C. Whether they know someone already on the team**
- D. Availability for weekend shifts**

11. According to Module 7, what are the four steps of the coaching structure?

- A. Observe specifically, ask before telling, listen for real understanding, guide toward the next attempt**
- B. Assign, inspect, report, review**
- C. Praise, correct, praise, dismiss**
- D. Warn, write up, monitor, escalate**

12. According to Module 7, when should a coaching issue move from informal coaching toward a formal performance conversation?

- A. When the same issue has been coached clearly more than once with no real change**
- B. After any single mistake, regardless of context**
- C. Immediately upon hire if the issue is noticed at all**
- D. Only after a full year of underperformance**

13. According to Module 8, what are the four parts of the structure for a difficult conversation?

- A. Situation, behavior, impact, expectation**
- B. Warning, consequence, probation, termination**
- C. Greeting, complaint, apology, resolution**
- D. Praise, criticize, praise, close**

14. According to Module 9, which of the six underlying needs is most directly tied to scheduling?

- A. Significance**
- B. Growth**
- C. Certainty**
- D. Contribution**

15. According to Module 10, what is the difference between a leading indicator and a lagging indicator?

- A. Leading indicators are always more accurate
- B. Lagging indicators only apply to Sales
- C. They are the same thing, described differently by department
- D. Lagging indicators show what already happened; leading indicators signal what's likely to happen next

16. According to Module 10, how many consecutive data points moving the same direction generally signal a real trend worth addressing directly?

- A. One
- B. Three or more
- C. A trend can never be identified mid-month
- D. Two

17. According to Module 11, what is gross profit?

- A. Net income before taxes
- B. Operating expenses minus labor cost
- C. Revenue with no deductions
- D. Revenue minus cost of goods

18. According to Module 11, what mistake does the module warn against when trying to control costs?

- A. Reviewing labor costs regularly
- B. Looking for waste and inefficiency first
- C. Cutting corners that damage the customer experience to achieve small savings
- D. Discussing budget limits honestly with the team

19. According to Module 12, what is the key difference between a "trusted riding consultant" and a "traditional salesperson"?

- A. A traditional salesperson only handles returning customers
- B. A trusted riding consultant focuses on the customer's right decision, which produces the sale as a byproduct
- C. There is no meaningful difference
- D. A trusted riding consultant does not participate in closing

20. According to Module 14, why is the rear counter treated with the same urgency as the front counter in Parts & Accessories?

- A. Technicians are given scheduling priority over all other customers
- B. The rear counter generates more revenue than the front counter
- C. Technicians are considered internal customers whose time directly equals dealership revenue
- D. It isn't — the front counter always takes priority

PART II

ADVANCED LEADERSHIP & THE GENERAL MANAGER

The judgment-and-leadership layer of management: completing your cross-department fluency, understanding the General Manager relationship, and building the skills that separate a manager who keeps a department running from one who makes it exceptional.

MODULE 15

Cross-Training Spotlight: F&I

F&I is the last conversation before ownership begins — and how it's handled either protects everything the customer has trusted the dealership with so far, or quietly undoes it in the final ten minutes.

F&I is the department managers outside of it understand the least, and misunderstand the most. It's easy to picture it as paperwork and upsells. In practice, done right, it's where the dealership makes sure a customer's protection actually matches how they're going to ride — the last real chance to get something right, or wrong, before the deal is done.

PART 1

WHY F&I FLUENCY MATTERS EVEN IF YOU DON'T RUN THE FINANCE OFFICE

F&I sits at the very end of the buying process, after a customer has already trusted Sales, evaluated the numbers, and made their decision. Whatever happens in that office in the final minutes shapes whether the customer leaves feeling good about the entire experience, or suddenly uneasy about a decision they were confident in five minutes earlier.

- ▶ F&I Academy trains F&I Managers, Sales Professionals, and Service Advisors together in the same manual, on purpose — all three roles need to understand this part of the customer journey, not just the F&I Manager
- ▶ A rushed or pressure-heavy F&I experience can undo genuine trust that Sales spent an entire process building
- ▶ A well-handled F&I conversation reinforces everything the customer has felt so far — that this dealership is looking out for them, not just closing a transaction

PART 2

OWNERSHIP PROTECTION, NOT HIGH-PRESSURE SELLING

F&I Academy trains every role that touches this conversation to help customers understand ownership protection — service contracts, coverage options, the financial side of ownership — without high-pressure selling. The training deliberately excludes specific product pitches in favor of the philosophy and communication approach underneath them.

- ▶ The goal of a good F&I conversation is a customer who understands their options and chooses confidently, not a customer who was talked into something they don't fully understand
- ▶ Transparency about what something costs and what it actually covers builds more trust, and ultimately more sales, than pressure ever does
- ▶ A customer who feels pressured in F&I often associates that discomfort with the entire dealership, not just the finance office — the stakes here extend well past this one conversation

PART 3

THE SHAPE OF A GOOD F&I CONVERSATION

- ▶ *Menu presentation.* Every option is presented clearly, without steering a customer toward the highest-cost choice by default
- ▶ *Plain-language explanation.* What a service contract or protection product actually covers, explained the way you'd explain it to a friend, not buried in fine print language

- ▶ *Room for real questions.* A customer should never feel rushed through this part of the process, even when the dealership is genuinely busy
- ▶ *Respecting a no.* A customer who declines a product should never feel a second, harder pitch — respecting the decision is part of the standard, not a failure to close

PART 4

WHAT TO WATCH FOR AS AN OUTSIDE MANAGER

- ▶ A customer who seems rushed or confused leaving the F&I office, the same way you'd watch for it leaving Sales or Service, is worth a quiet check-in
- ▶ Genuine transparency about pricing and coverage looks very different from a scripted pitch — exposure to the department over time builds a real feel for the difference
- ▶ As with every other department, raise concerns with the F&I Manager directly rather than addressing their team member yourself

PART 5

F&I'S ROLE IN THE PASSPORT JOURNEY

F&I often marks the formal close of the buying journey and the true start of the ownership relationship — a natural point for Passport to hand the customer forward into Service and Parts with real intention, not just a signature and a handshake.

- ▶ A strong F&I handoff introduces the customer to what ownership actually looks like going forward — their first service interval, how Parts can help them personalize the bike, what to expect next
- ▶ F&I is also where a customer's trust either solidifies or takes a hit right before the relationship with the rest of the dealership truly begins — the stakes for a clean, honest handoff are genuinely high
- ▶ A customer who leaves F&I feeling well cared for tends to walk into their first service visit already predisposed to trust the process

PART 6

STEPPING IN WITHOUT OVERSTEPPING

WEAK: *(covering during a staffing gap, a customer asks a specific coverage question) "I think that one covers most things, should be fine."* — a guess dressed up as an answer, on a topic where accuracy genuinely matters.

STRONG: *"I want to make sure you get the exact right answer on that, since it matters — let me get you with someone from our F&I team so you have the complete picture, not just my best guess."*

Financial and coverage accuracy carries real weight for the customer — this is one of the clearest boundaries in the entire manual for when an honest handoff matters more than appearing helpful in the moment.

- ▶ Never guess at coverage details, pricing, or financing terms — the cost of being wrong here is higher than in almost any other department
- ▶ Familiarity with the F&I philosophy lets you reinforce the "no pressure" standard even without deep product knowledge
- ▶ A manager who understands this department's role in the customer's overall trust, even without running it day to day, is protecting something bigger than a single transaction

GOAL OF MODULE 15

Every manager understands the ownership-protection philosophy behind F&I, recognizes the shape of a well-run F&I conversation, understands F&I's role as the hinge point in the Passport journey between the sale and the ownership relationship, and knows never to guess at coverage or pricing details when covering the department.

MODULE 16 — Leading Managers: The GM's Role

MODULE 15 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, why does F&I Academy train F&I Managers, Sales Professionals, and Service Advisors together in one manual?

- A. Only F&I Managers actually need this training**
- B. It's required by state financing regulations**
- C. All three roles touch this part of the customer journey and need to understand it, not just the F&I Manager**
- D. Sales Professionals handle all F&I paperwork themselves**

2. According to Part 2, what does F&I Academy deliberately exclude from its training?

- A. Specific product pitches, in favor of the philosophy and approach underneath them**
- B. Communication philosophy and transparency principles**
- C. How to explain coverage in plain language**
- D. How to handle a customer's questions**

3. According to Part 3, what should happen when a customer declines a protection product?

- A. A second, harder pitch should follow to ensure they understood the offer**
- B. The decision should be respected, not treated as a failure to close**
- C. A manager should be called in to attempt the sale instead**
- D. The sale should be paused until they reconsider**

4. According to Part 5, what does F&I often mark the formal close of?

- A. The buying journey, and the true start of the ownership relationship**
- B. The customer's relationship with the dealership entirely**
- C. The Passport process, which ends once financing is signed**
- D. The Sales Professional's involvement with future visits**

5. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 6, why does the STRONG version avoid guessing at a coverage question?

- A. Customers rarely ask about coverage specifics**
- B. The cost of being wrong on financial or coverage details is higher than in almost any other department**
- C. Guessing is against F&I Academy's core philosophy but has no real consequence**
- D. Coverage questions are outside any employee's responsibility**

MODULE 16

Leading Managers: The GM's Role

Managing an employee, you're responsible for the work. Managing a manager, you're responsible for how well someone else leads other people's work — and that's a completely different kind of accountability.

If you're stepping into a General Manager role, or working toward one, this module marks a real shift in altitude. Everything covered so far in this manual — coaching, hiring, scheduling, reading numbers, culture — still matters and still applies directly to your own team. What changes is that your team is now made up of managers, each running their own department, each carrying their own version of everything this manual has covered. Your job is no longer just to lead people. It's to lead leaders.

PART 1

WHAT CHANGES WHEN YOUR TEAM IS MADE OF MANAGERS

A GM doesn't run the Sales floor, the Service shop, the Parts counter, or the F&I office directly — department managers do that. A GM's real job is making sure each of those managers is leading well, and that the dealership functions as one coordinated operation rather than four separate ones that happen to share a building.

- ▶ Your success is now measured almost entirely through other managers' success — a step further removed from direct outcomes than even a department manager experiences
- ▶ The instinct to jump in and personally fix a department-level problem is even more tempting at this level, and even more corrosive to the manager whose department it is
- ▶ A GM who quietly runs every department themselves through their managers isn't actually developing leaders — they're just adding a layer of management on top of doing the work themselves

YOUR JOB AS A GM ISN'T TO RUN FOUR DEPARTMENTS. IT'S TO BUILD FOUR MANAGERS WHO CAN

PART 2

THE FORCE MULTIPLIER EFFECT

Every hour a GM spends developing a department manager's judgment pays off every day that manager is running their department — a GM who coaches well multiplies their own impact across every department, every shift, whether or not they're personally present.

- ▶ Coaching a department manager well is a far higher-leverage use of a GM's time than personally solving a single problem in that department
- ▶ A GM who builds strong managers can be out of the building for a week and the dealership runs well. A GM who hasn't can't
- ▶ This is Module 2's lesson about letting go of hero work, applied one level higher — the instinct to personally fix things doesn't disappear as you rise, it just gets more expensive when you give in to it

PART 3

CONSISTENCY ACROSS YOUR MANAGEMENT TEAM

Just as Module 3 warned against uneven standards within a single department, a GM has to watch for uneven standards across department managers — favoring one department, one manager's style, or one manager's personality over the others erodes trust across the whole dealership.

- ▶ Hold every department manager to the same core standard, even as their individual departments and personalities differ
- ▶ Avoid letting your favorite department, or the manager you personally get along with best, receive more attention, resources, or leniency than the others
- ▶ Department managers watch how you treat their peers as closely as they watch how you treat them directly — perceived favoritism among managers spreads distrust fast

PART 4

COACHING A MANAGER IS DIFFERENT FROM COACHING AN EMPLOYEE

The observe-ask-listen-guide structure from Module 7 still applies, but coaching a manager requires a different kind of restraint. A department manager needs room to develop their own judgment, which means a GM often has to resist handing over the answer even when it would genuinely be faster.

- ▶ Ask more, tell less, even more deliberately than you would with a frontline employee — a manager's whole job is building judgment, and judgment isn't built by being handed conclusions
- ▶ When a department manager makes a defensible decision you would have made differently, let it stand rather than overriding it — disagreement on approach isn't the same as the decision being wrong
- ▶ Reserve direct intervention for situations with real stakes — safety, ethics, a genuine standard violation — not simply "I would have done it differently"

PART 5

COACHING A STRUGGLING DEPARTMENT MANAGER

WEAK: *"Your numbers are down and I need you to fix it. Figure it out."* — offers pressure without any real support, and treats a manager the way an under-coached manager might treat a frontline employee.

STRONG: *"I've been watching your numbers over the last few weeks, and I want to understand what you're seeing on your end before I share my read. Walk me through what you think is driving it, and let's figure out together what needs to change."*

The strong version treats the department manager as a leader capable of real analysis, not as an employee waiting to be told what to do — while still being direct that the numbers need to change. Coaching a manager well models exactly the kind of coaching you want them running with their own team.

- ▶ Ask for their diagnosis before offering your own — a manager who's coached to think will out-perform one who's simply told what to do, over the long run
- ▶ Be honest about the stakes without removing their ownership of the solution
- ▶ A GM who solves every department manager's problem for them is quietly training every department manager to stop trying to solve their own

PART 6

KNOWING WHEN TO STEP IN VERSUS WHEN TO LET GO

Every GM eventually faces the judgment call of when a department genuinely needs direct intervention versus when it needs to be left in its manager's hands, even through a rough stretch.

- ▶ A single hard month, a manager still finding their footing, or a defensible decision you'd have made differently are almost always better left alone than intervened on directly

- ▶ A genuine standard violation, a safety issue, or a pattern that's gone on despite real coaching are situations that warrant direct intervention
- ▶ When you do need to step in, do it in a way that supports the department manager's authority with their own team rather than undermining it in front of them

GOAL OF MODULE 16

Every General Manager understands that their job is building strong department managers rather than running departments directly, applies consistent standards across their whole management team, coaches managers by asking rather than telling, and knows the difference between a moment that needs direct intervention and one that needs to be left in a manager's hands.

MODULE 17 — Dealership-Wide Strategy & Cross-Department Alignment

MODULE 16 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what is a General Manager's real job, as described in this module?
 - A. Personally running each department directly
 - B. Handling only the financial reporting for the dealership
 - C. Serving as a backup employee for each department
 - D. Making sure each department manager is leading well, and that the dealership functions as one coordinated operation
2. According to Part 2, why is coaching a department manager described as a "force multiplier"?
 - A. It replaces the need for department-level coaching entirely
 - B. It reduces the GM's own workload with no other benefit
 - C. It only benefits the manager being coached, not the dealership
 - D. It pays off every day that manager runs their department, multiplying the GM's impact without requiring their constant presence
3. According to Part 3, what does this module warn against regarding a GM's relationship with different department managers?
 - A. Letting a favorite department or manager receive more leniency or resources than the others
 - B. Meeting individually with each department manager
 - C. Coaching managers using the observe-ask-listen-guide structure
 - D. Holding all managers to the same core standard
4. According to Part 4, what should a GM generally do when a department manager makes a defensible decision the GM would have made differently?
 - A. Quietly redo the decision without telling the manager
 - B. Let the decision stand, since disagreement on approach isn't the same as the decision being wrong
 - C. Escalate the decision to corporate for review
 - D. Override the decision to maintain consistency
5. According to Part 6, what kind of situation warrants a GM's direct intervention in a department?
 - A. Any decision the GM personally would have made differently
 - B. A genuine standard violation, safety issue, or an uncoached pattern that persists
 - C. A single hard month for an otherwise capable manager
 - D. A manager still finding their footing early in the role

MODULE 17

Dealership-Wide Strategy & Cross-Department Alignment

Every department manager is optimizing for their own department. Somebody has to optimize for the whole dealership — that's you.

Left entirely to their own instincts, department managers will naturally prioritize their own department's numbers, their own department's schedule, their own department's problems. That's not a flaw — it's exactly what a good department manager should be doing. It also means friction between departments is inevitable, and somebody has to be the person who sees the whole picture and keeps the departments pulling in the same direction instead of quietly working against each other.

PART 1

THE GM AS CONNECTIVE TISSUE

No single department manager is positioned to see the whole dealership the way a GM does. Sales sees Sales. Service sees Service. A GM sees where Sales' decisions land on F&I, where Service's scheduling affects Parts, where a bottleneck in one department quietly becomes a problem in another.

- ▶ Cross-department friction is normal, not a sign that anyone is doing something wrong — it's the natural result of departments each optimizing for their own priorities
- ▶ A GM's job is to catch that friction before it becomes dysfunction, and to make sure every department manager understands how their decisions ripple outward
- ▶ The four department managers report to you individually — but the dealership only functions well as one team, and building that sense of one team is a GM-specific responsibility no department manager can fully own themselves

PART 2

WHERE DEPARTMENTS NATURALLY COLLIDE

Certain friction points show up again and again across dealerships, and recognizing the pattern helps a GM get ahead of it rather than simply reacting each time it flares up.

- ▶ Sales' pace and volume can put pressure on F&I to move faster than a thorough, no-pressure conversation really allows
- ▶ Service scheduling and Parts availability are tightly linked — a Service Manager who doesn't communicate upcoming volume leaves Parts scrambling, and a Parts Manager who doesn't flag backorders early leaves Service overpromising customers
- ▶ Sales' promises during a deal sometimes outpace what Service or Parts can actually deliver on the timeline promised, leaving those departments to manage a customer's disappointed expectations they didn't create

PART 3

RESOLVING CONFLICT WITHOUT PICKING SIDES

When two department managers are in real conflict — over a process, a customer situation, a resource — a GM's instinct to quickly side with one or the other, even unconsciously, damages trust with whoever wasn't chosen. The better approach treats the conflict as a shared problem to solve, not a dispute to referee.

- ▶ Hear both sides fully before forming a view, even when one story initially sounds more compelling

- ▶ Frame the conversation around what's best for the customer and the dealership as a whole, not around who's "right"
- ▶ If a genuine mistake was made by one department, address it directly and fairly — avoiding the issue to preserve harmony isn't actually neutral, it just lets the same friction resurface later

A GM WHO PLAYS FAVORITES BETWEEN DEPARTMENTS TEACHES EVERY MANAGER TO COMPETE INSTEAD OF COOPERATE

PART 4

MEDIATING A CROSS-DEPARTMENT CONFLICT

WEAK: *"Look, Sales brings in the revenue, so let's try to make this work on their timeline."* — resolves the immediate friction by simply picking the louder or higher-visibility department, which quietly teaches every other manager where they really rank.

STRONG: *"I hear both of you. Sales, I understand the pressure to move fast on this deal. Service, I understand you can't promise a timeline you can't actually hit. Let's figure out what's realistic together, and let's talk about how we flag this kind of thing earlier next time so we're not solving it under pressure."*

The strong version validates both perspectives, focuses on a realistic solution rather than a winner, and — just as importantly — addresses the process gap that created the friction in the first place, so the same conflict is less likely to resurface.

- ▶ Validate what's legitimate in each manager's position before moving toward a solution
- ▶ Solve the immediate problem and the underlying process gap — fixing only the immediate issue guarantees a repeat
- ▶ Follow up with both managers afterward to make sure the resolution actually held, not just that the conversation ended calmly

PART 5

OWNING PASSPORT ACROSS THE WHOLE DEALERSHIP

Every department manager owns Passport within their own department, per Module 3. A GM owns it across all four — making sure the thread that connects Sales to F&I to Service to Parts, and back again, actually holds together as one continuous customer experience rather than four disconnected good intentions.

- ▶ Periodically walk the full customer journey yourself, department to department, the way a customer actually experiences it — problems that are invisible within a single department are often obvious end to end
- ▶ When one department's Passport handoff is consistently weak, it's rarely just that department's problem — it usually affects how the next department receives that customer too
- ▶ A GM who treats Passport as "the individual departments' job" misses that the entire point of Passport is the connective tissue between departments — which is a GM-level responsibility by definition

PART 6

BUILDING DEALERSHIP-WIDE RHYTHMS

Cross-department alignment doesn't happen by accident — it requires deliberate, regular touchpoints where all four department managers are in the same room, seeing the same picture.

- ▶ A regular management team meeting, focused on dealership-wide numbers and cross-department issues rather than each department reporting in isolation, keeps everyone oriented to the same reality
- ▶ Sharing dealership-wide metrics with all department managers, not just their own department's numbers, builds the habit of thinking beyond their own silo
- ▶ Celebrating cross-department wins publicly — a smooth handoff, a problem two departments solved together — reinforces the behavior you actually want to see more of

GOAL OF MODULE 17

Every General Manager understands their unique role as the connective tissue across departments, recognizes where cross-department friction naturally arises, resolves conflict by solving the shared problem rather than picking a side, and owns Passport as a dealership-wide thread rather than four separate departmental efforts.

MODULE 18 — *The GM as Culture Carrier*

MODULE 17 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

- 1. According to Part 1, why is a GM uniquely positioned to catch cross-department friction?**
 - A. GMs personally handle every customer complaint**
 - B. Department managers are not permitted to communicate with each other directly**
 - C. GMs are trained in every department's specific technical skills**
 - D. No single department manager sees the whole dealership the way a GM does**
- 2. According to Part 2, what is a common friction point between Sales and F&I?**
 - A. F&I sets pricing for every motorcycle sold**
 - B. F&I has no interaction with the Sales process at all**
 - C. Sales' pace and volume can pressure F&I to move faster than a thorough conversation allows**
 - D. Sales and F&I never interact on the same deal**
- 3. According to Part 3, what should a GM avoid doing when two department managers are in conflict?**
 - A. Quickly siding with one manager, even unconsciously, before understanding the full picture**
 - B. Hearing both sides before forming a view**
 - C. Framing the conversation around what's best for the dealership as a whole**
 - D. Addressing a genuine mistake directly and fairly**
- 4. In the WEAK/STRONG mediation example in Part 4, what does the STRONG version do that the WEAK version doesn't?**
 - A. It avoids proposing any solution at all**
 - B. It defers the decision to corporate**
 - C. It immediately sides with the department bringing in more revenue**
 - D. It validates both perspectives and addresses the underlying process gap, not just the immediate friction**
- 5. According to Part 5, what is a GM's specific responsibility regarding Passport, beyond what an individual department manager owns?**
 - A. None — Passport is entirely a department-level responsibility**
 - B. Personally performing every customer handoff**
 - C. Auditing Passport compliance only once per year**
 - D. Making sure the Passport thread holds together as one continuous experience across all four departments**

MODULE 18

The GM as Culture Carrier

A department manager sets the tone for their own team. A General Manager sets the tone for what "tone" even means at this dealership — whether every manager here is actually accountable for, or just something painted on the wall downstairs.

Module 3 taught that culture is what a manager tolerates, not what they state. At the GM level, that same principle scales up to the entire dealership — and the stakes get higher, because a GM's tolerance or intolerance doesn't just shape one department's culture, it shapes what every department manager believes the real standard is, whether or not it matches what's written in any manual.

PART 1

CULTURE STARTS AT THE TOP, WHETHER OR NOT THE GM WANTS IT TO

Every department manager is watching how their GM behaves far more closely than they're listening to what their GM says. If a GM talks about the customer standard but quietly lets numbers justify cutting corners, every department manager learns that numbers actually outrank the standard, no matter what gets said in meetings.

- ▶ A GM doesn't get to opt out of setting culture — it happens automatically, through what gets rewarded, ignored, and corrected
- ▶ The gap between a GM's stated values and a GM's actual behavior is the fastest thing every manager in the building learns to read
- ▶ A GM who wants a genuinely strong culture has to accept that they are, whether comfortable with it or not, the single biggest influence on whether that culture is real

PART 2

EMBODYING "LIVE THE PASSION" RATHER THAN JUST REPEATING IT

Every employee at every level hears the tagline during training. Very few employees are moved by a tagline itself — they're moved by watching someone who actually embodies it, especially someone at the top of the organization.

- ▶ A GM who's visibly present on the floor, engaged with customers and employees, communicates the standard more powerfully than any meeting or memo
- ▶ A GM who treats the tagline as marketing language rather than an actual operating philosophy signals, without saying so, that it's optional for everyone else too
- ▶ Small, consistent actions — genuinely knowing employees' names across every department, actually stopping to talk with a customer, following up on something a manager mentioned weeks earlier — do more for culture than any single speech

A TAGLINE REPEATED BY LEADERSHIP MEANS NOTHING. A TAGLINE VISIBLY LIVED BY LEADERSHIP MEANS EVERYTHING

PART 3

LEADING LEADERS THROUGH THEIR OWN UNDERLYING NEEDS

The six underlying needs from Module 4 — certainty, variety, significance, connection, growth, contribution — don't stop applying once someone becomes a manager. Department managers have the

same underlying drivers as anyone else, and a GM who understands which needs are running each of their managers leads them far more effectively than one who treats every manager identically.

- ▶ A department manager driven by significance often needs genuine recognition from the GM specifically, not just from their own team — it can be lonely at the top of a department, and that recognition matters more than it might seem
- ▶ A department manager driven by growth benefits enormously from a GM who's actively thinking about their next step, not just their current performance
- ▶ A department manager driven by certainty needs a GM who communicates dealership-wide changes clearly and early, rather than leaving managers to hear about decisions secondhand

PART 4

ADDRESSING A DEALERSHIP-WIDE CULTURE SLIP

WEAK: *(noticing standards slipping across multiple departments) "I've been seeing some things lately — everyone just needs to tighten up."* — vague enough that no manager feels specifically responsible, and nothing concrete changes.

STRONG: *"I want to name something directly with all of you. Over the last few weeks, I've seen Passport handoffs get inconsistent in more than one department, and I think it's connected to how busy things have been. I'm not pointing fingers — I want us to solve this together, starting with each of you doing a quick audit of your own team this week and reporting back what you find."*

The strong version is specific, takes shared ownership of the underlying cause rather than purely blaming managers, and gives every manager a concrete, immediate action — exactly the standard this manual has taught throughout for addressing performance at any level.

- ▶ Address a dealership-wide slip directly with the whole management team, not through individual side conversations that let the pattern stay invisible
- ▶ Model the same directness-without-blame standard taught in Module 8, now applied to your management team rather than an individual employee
- ▶ Follow up concretely — a culture conversation without a real follow-up plan is exactly the kind of standard that's stated once and never enforced, which Module 3 warned erodes trust fastest

PART 5

WHAT EMPLOYEES LEARN FROM WATCHING HOW THE GM TREATS MANAGERS

Frontline employees rarely interact with the GM directly and constantly, but they watch closely how their own manager is treated by the GM — respectfully or dismissively, fairly or unevenly — and that observation shapes how much they trust the whole leadership structure above them.

- ▶ A GM who publicly undermines a department manager's authority, even unintentionally, damages that manager's ability to lead their own team
- ▶ A GM who visibly respects and supports department managers, even while holding them accountable, reinforces the whole leadership chain all the way down to the newest hire
- ▶ Employees generally trust an organization roughly as much as they trust how its leaders treat each other — a principle worth remembering at every level of this manual, not just the top

PART 6

THE COST OF A GM WHO TALKS CULTURE BUT DOESN'T LIVE IT

A dealership can survive a rough quarter. A dealership has a much harder time surviving a genuine erosion of trust between leadership and the people actually doing the work — and that erosion almost always traces back to a real gap between what leadership says and what leadership does.

- ▶ Employees forgive an honest, acknowledged mistake far more easily than they forgive a leader who pretends the standard applies to everyone except themselves
- ▶ A culture that only holds up when the GM is present isn't a real culture — it's compliance, and it collapses the moment attention shifts elsewhere
- ▶ The standard set out in this manual, all the way back to Module 3, applies with the most weight at the top of the organization, not the least

GOAL OF MODULE 18

Every General Manager understands that culture is set by what they actually do, not what they say; embodies the Motos America standard visibly rather than treating it as language; leads department managers by understanding their individual underlying needs; and addresses dealership-wide culture slips directly, specifically, and with real follow-up.

MODULE 19 — Rapid Planning for Department Goals

MODULE 18 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what determines a dealership's real culture, according to this module?
 - A. What gets rewarded, ignored, and corrected by leadership — not what leadership says
 - B. The written employee handbook
 - C. How long the dealership has been in business
 - D. The dealership's annual revenue
2. According to Part 2, what does this module say does more for culture than a single speech from leadership?
 - A. A quarterly all-staff meeting
 - B. Small, consistent actions like knowing employees' names and following up on things managers mentioned weeks earlier
 - C. Posting the tagline in more locations throughout the dealership
 - D. A well-designed employee handbook
3. According to Part 3, why might a department manager driven by significance need recognition specifically from the GM?
 - A. Department managers are not permitted to receive recognition from their own teams
 - B. Recognition from their own team doesn't count toward performance reviews
 - C. It can be lonely at the top of a department, and recognition from the GM carries particular weight
 - D. GM recognition is required for any promotion consideration
4. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 4, what does the STRONG version do differently?
 - A. Is specific, takes shared ownership of the cause, and gives every manager a concrete action
 - B. Blames a specific department manager by name
 - C. Avoids naming the issue directly to preserve morale
 - D. Handles the issue through individual side conversations only
5. According to Part 6, what does this module say about a culture that only holds up when the GM is present?
 - A. It isn't a real culture — it's compliance, and it collapses once attention shifts elsewhere
 - B. That's the expected and desired outcome
 - C. It indicates the GM should be present more often as a permanent solution
 - D. It only matters if it affects revenue directly

MODULE 19

Rapid Planning for Department Goals

"Increase sales this quarter" isn't a goal. It's a wish wearing a goal's clothes — and a team can't actually act on a wish.

Most department goals fail for a simple, fixable reason: they were never actually built to be acted on. They were stated, posted somewhere, and left to hope. A goal that produces real results has a specific shape — a clear outcome, a real reason behind it, and a first set of concrete moves, rather than a vague direction and an assumption that everyone will figure out the rest.

PART 1

WHY MOST DEPARTMENT GOALS FAIL BEFORE THEY START

Ask most teams what their department's current goal is, and you'll often get a fuzzy answer — "do better," "hit our numbers," "improve customer satisfaction." None of that is wrong exactly, but none of it is specific enough for anyone to actually act on differently starting tomorrow morning.

- ▶ A goal without a specific outcome gives the team nothing concrete to measure progress against
- ▶ A goal without a real reason behind it relies purely on willpower, which reliably runs out under pressure
- ▶ A goal without a first move stays a good intention indefinitely — intentions don't hit numbers, actions do

A GOAL YOU CAN'T DESCRIBE IN ONE SPECIFIC SENTENCE ISN'T A GOAL YET — IT'S STILL JUST A DIRECTION

PART 2

START WITH THE RESULT, NOT THE TASK LIST

Most planning starts backward — a list of tasks first, with the hoped-for outcome only loosely attached at the end. Stronger planning starts with a crystal-clear picture of the actual result, and works backward from there to figure out what needs to happen to produce it.

- ▶ Define the result specifically enough that everyone on the team would recognize it the moment it happened — "increase accessory attach rate from 22% to 30% by the end of the quarter," not "sell more accessories"
- ▶ A specific result also tells you specifically when you've succeeded, which a vague goal never can
- ▶ Once the result is genuinely clear, the tasks that lead to it usually become far more obvious than they were when the process started with the task list itself

PART 3

CONNECTING THE RESULT TO A REAL REASON

A number alone rarely sustains real motivation once the initial energy of setting the goal wears off, usually within the first couple of weeks. What sustains it is a genuine reason the team actually cares about — connected, wherever possible, to the underlying needs covered in Module 4.

- ▶ A goal tied to significance — "we become the team known for this" — motivates differently than a goal tied only to a number on a dashboard

- ▶ A goal tied to contribution — "this is what actually helps the customer get what they need" — often outlasts a goal tied purely to hitting a target
- ▶ Ask the team directly what would make this goal actually matter to them, rather than assuming the number alone will be reason enough

PART 4

BUILDING THE FIRST MOVES, NOT THE ENTIRE PLAN

Over-planning is a common trap — spending so much time building the complete, detailed plan that the team never actually gets moving, or the plan is already stale by the time it's finished. A better approach identifies the first few concrete moves clearly, gets moving, and adjusts the rest of the plan as real information comes in.

- ▶ Identify the two or three actions that would make the biggest difference toward the result, and start there rather than trying to map every step in advance
- ▶ Real-world feedback from the first few weeks of action almost always improves the plan more than additional time spent planning in a vacuum would
- ▶ A clear first move creates momentum. A perfect, fully mapped plan that hasn't started yet creates none

PART 5

SETTING A GOAL WITH YOUR TEAM

WEAK: *"Our numbers need to be better this quarter. Let's all push harder."* — a direction with no specific result, no real reason, and no concrete first move.

STRONG: *"Here's exactly where I want us to be by the end of the quarter, and here's why it actually matters — not just for the dashboard, but for what it means for how customers experience us and what it means for each of you. Let's talk about the two things we could start doing differently this week that would move us toward that."*

The strong version gives the team a specific result to aim at, a reason that connects to something they genuinely care about, and an immediate, concrete starting point — all three pieces this module has covered, working together rather than any one alone.

- ▶ State the specific result before anything else — vagueness at the start undermines everything that follows
- ▶ Let the team help identify the reason that matters most to them, rather than assuming you already know
- ▶ End with something they can start doing this week, not a plan to revisit "when things settle down"

PART 6

REVISITING WITHOUT ABANDONING

Plans built with real intention still need adjustment as reality unfolds — that's not a sign the original goal was wrong, it's a normal part of pursuing any meaningful result.

- ▶ Check in on progress regularly enough to adjust the plan before a small miss becomes a large one
- ▶ When something isn't working, change the approach, not the underlying result — abandoning the goal itself the moment the first plan hits friction teaches a team that goals aren't really serious
- ▶ Celebrate genuine progress along the way, not only the final result — momentum built from small wins is what carries a team through the harder stretches of a longer goal

GOAL OF MODULE 19

Every manager can build a department goal around a specific result, a genuine reason the team actually cares about, and a concrete first move — and can adjust the plan as reality unfolds without abandoning the goal itself at the first sign of friction.

MODULE 20 — Building High-Performance Teams

MODULE 19 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what does this module say is missing from a vague goal like "do better" or "hit our numbers"?
 - A. Anything specific enough for the team to actually act on differently starting tomorrow
 - B. Corporate approval
 - C. A large enough team to execute it
 - D. A connection to the dashboard
2. According to Part 2, what does this module recommend starting planning with?
 - A. A detailed task list first, with the result attached loosely at the end
 - B. The team's current schedule
 - C. A budget review
 - D. A specific, clearly defined result, working backward to the tasks that produce it
3. According to Part 3, what tends to sustain motivation toward a goal longer than the number itself?
 - A. Frequent reminders about the deadline
 - B. A genuine reason connected to something the team actually cares about, such as significance or contribution
 - C. Keeping the goal private until it's achieved
 - D. A larger financial incentive in every case
4. According to Part 4, what is the recommended approach to planning, rather than mapping every step in advance?
 - A. Assign the entire plan to one team member to execute alone
 - B. Identify a few concrete first moves, start, and adjust as real feedback comes in
 - C. Wait until the complete, detailed plan is finished before taking any action
 - D. Avoid setting any timeline until the plan is complete
5. According to Part 6, what should change when part of a plan isn't working?
 - A. The approach should change, while the underlying result stays the same
 - B. Nothing — plans should never be adjusted once set
 - C. The underlying result should be abandoned immediately
 - D. The team should stop checking in on progress until the deadline

MODULE 20

Building High-Performance Teams

A good team gets the job done. A high-performing team makes each other better while they're doing it — and that difference doesn't happen by accident.

Every manager wants a high-performing team. Far fewer managers actually build the specific conditions that produce one. High performance isn't the result of hiring exceptional individuals and hoping their talent adds up — it's the result of a manager deliberately building trust, healthy accountability, and real recognition into how the team actually operates day to day.

PART 1

WHAT ACTUALLY SEPARATES A GOOD TEAM FROM A HIGH-PERFORMING ONE

A good team hits its numbers most of the time and gets along reasonably well. A high-performing team does something more — its members hold each other accountable without being asked to, cover for each other genuinely rather than resentfully, and consistently perform above what their individual talent alone would predict.

- ▶ Talent matters, but it's not the differentiator most managers assume it is — plenty of talented individuals make up a mediocre team
- ▶ The differentiator is almost always the environment the manager has built, not the raw ability of the people in it
- ▶ A high-performing team is built deliberately, over time, through specific and repeatable practices — not discovered by luck in a great hiring cycle

PART 2

TRUST AS THE FOUNDATION

Every practice in this module rests on a foundation of real trust — between the manager and the team, and among team members themselves. Without it, accountability reads as punishment, recognition reads as manipulation, and feedback reads as an attack rather than help.

- ▶ Trust is built the same way described throughout this manual — consistency, fairness, follow-through, and treating people well even when it's inconvenient
- ▶ A team that trusts its manager will tell that manager the truth, including uncomfortable truths — a team that doesn't will simply tell the manager what they think the manager wants to hear
- ▶ Trust between team members, not just between the team and the manager, is what actually produces genuine mutual accountability — a manager has to actively build both

PART 3

HEALTHY CONFLICT AND REAL ACCOUNTABILITY

High-performing teams aren't conflict-free — they're teams where disagreement happens openly and productively instead of quietly, behind each other's backs. A team where everyone always agrees isn't harmonious; it's usually a team where people have stopped saying what they actually think.

- ▶ Model disagreeing with a team member's idea respectfully yourself, so the team sees that disagreement and respect aren't mutually exclusive
- ▶ Watch for a team that's suspiciously conflict-free — it often signals people have learned that speaking up isn't safe, not that everything is genuinely fine

- ▶ Peer accountability — team members holding each other to the standard without the manager having to intervene every time — is one of the clearest signs a team has actually reached high performance

A HIGH-PERFORMING TEAM ISN'T ONE THAT NEVER DISAGREES. IT'S ONE THAT DISAGREES OUT LOUD AND STILL TRUSTS EACH OTHER AFTERWARD

PART 4

RECOGNITION AND INCENTIVES THAT ACTUALLY WORK

Module 4's underlying-needs framework applies directly here — recognition and incentive structures that ignore what actually drives different individuals tend to motivate only a fraction of the team, while genuinely tailored recognition reaches far more people.

- ▶ A single incentive structure rarely motivates an entire team equally — pair standard incentives with recognition that's tailored to what actually matters to each person
- ▶ Public recognition works powerfully for team members driven by significance, and can genuinely backfire for team members driven more by connection or humility — know the difference before defaulting to one style for everyone
- ▶ The most sustainable form of recognition is specific and tied to real behavior, not generic praise handed out on a schedule regardless of what actually happened

PART 5

BUILDING TEAM OWNERSHIP OF A STRETCH GOAL

WEAK: *"I need everyone to hit these new numbers starting Monday."* — a directive from above, with no team ownership built into it at all.

STRONG: *"I want to set an ambitious goal for us this quarter, and I want to build it with you, not just hand it to you. Here's where I think we could realistically push to — what do you think it would actually take to get there, and what would you need from me to make it happen?"*

The strong version treats the team as genuine partners in setting the bar, not just the people responsible for clearing it — and teams that help set a stretch goal tend to own it far more completely than teams that were simply handed one.

- ▶ Involve the team in shaping the goal wherever genuinely possible, not just in executing a goal set entirely without them
- ▶ Ask what they'd need from you specifically to hit it — this often surfaces real obstacles you weren't aware of
- ▶ A stretch goal the team helped build tends to generate real internal accountability; one that was purely handed down tends to generate compliance at best

PART 6

SUSTAINING HIGH PERFORMANCE WITHOUT BURNOUT

High performance sustained through constant pressure eventually breaks — a team that's run at maximum intensity indefinitely eventually loses its best people, exhausted, to somewhere less demanding. Real high performance is sustainable, not just intense.

- ▶ Watch for the warning signs of burnout across the team, not just underperformance — exhaustion often looks like slipping standards before it looks like anything else
- ▶ Build in genuine recovery, not just relentless intensity — a team that's allowed to recover between pushes performs better over the long run than one that's never given the chance

- ▶ A manager who celebrates genuine wins, not just relentlessly raises the bar the moment one goal is hit, builds a team that wants to keep performing rather than one that's quietly waiting to burn out

GOAL OF MODULE 20

Every manager understands that high performance is built deliberately through trust, healthy conflict, and tailored recognition — and can build genuine team ownership of ambitious goals while protecting the team from burning out in pursuit of them.

MODULE 21 — Conflict Resolution & Crucial Conversations Across Departments

MODULE 20 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what does this module say is the real differentiator between a good team and a high-performing one?

- A. The department's overall budget**
- B. The size of the team**
- C. The individual talent level of the team members**
- D. The environment the manager has deliberately built, not raw individual talent**

2. According to Part 2, what happens when accountability and feedback are attempted without a foundation of real trust?

- A. The team automatically becomes more productive**
- B. Accountability reads as punishment and feedback reads as an attack rather than help**
- C. They work exactly as well as they would with trust in place**
- D. Trust becomes irrelevant to team performance**

3. According to Part 3, what does a team that is "suspiciously conflict-free" often actually signal?

- A. A well-designed incentive structure**
- B. That people have learned speaking up isn't safe, not that everything is fine**
- C. Strong peer accountability**
- D. Genuine harmony and alignment**

4. According to Part 4, why doesn't a single incentive structure motivate an entire team equally?

- A. Public recognition works equally well for every team member**
- B. Incentives should never be used in a management setting**
- C. Only financial incentives have any real effect**
- D. Different team members are driven by different underlying needs, so tailored recognition reaches more people**

5. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 5, what does the STRONG version do differently when setting a stretch goal?

- A. It builds the goal with the team, inviting their input on what it would take to reach it**
- B. It assigns the goal to only the team's top performer**
- C. It lowers the goal to make it easier to reach**
- D. It sets the goal without any team involvement to save time**

MODULE 21

Conflict Resolution & Crucial Conversations Across Departments

A conversation with real stakes, real disagreement, and real emotion attached to it doesn't get easier by avoiding it. It just gets postponed to a worse version of itself, usually with someone else in the room by then.

Every manager eventually faces a conversation that matters — high stakes, genuine disagreement, real feelings involved on one or both sides. These conversations are hardest across departments, where you don't have direct authority over the other person and the relationship has to survive the disagreement intact, because you'll be working alongside them again tomorrow regardless of how today's conversation goes.

PART 1

WHY CROSS-DEPARTMENT CONFLICT FEELS DIFFERENT

Within your own department, you have real authority to set a decision and move forward. With a peer manager, you have no such authority — only influence, relationship, and the strength of your own reasoning. That changes how these conversations have to be handled.

- ▶ You can't simply decide the outcome of a cross-department disagreement the way you might within your own team
- ▶ The relationship with that peer manager has to survive the conversation, because you'll need their cooperation again soon, likely often
- ▶ Cross-department conflict handled poorly doesn't stay contained to the two people involved — it tends to bleed into how their respective teams treat each other too

PART 2

RECOGNIZING A CRUCIAL CONVERSATION FOR WHAT IT IS

A conversation becomes genuinely crucial when three things are present at once: real stakes, real disagreement, and real emotion. Recognizing when you're actually in one of these — rather than treating it like a routine exchange — changes how carefully you should approach it.

- ▶ *High stakes.* The outcome genuinely matters — to the customer, the team, or the working relationship itself
- ▶ *Differing views.* You and the other person see the situation meaningfully differently, not just a minor detail apart
- ▶ *Strong emotion.* Frustration, defensiveness, or tension is present, even if it's not loudly expressed

When all three are present, the normal rules of a casual conversation don't apply — the conversation deserves real preparation and real care, the same way Module 8 taught for a difficult conversation within your own team.

PART 3

STAYING IN DIALOGUE INSTEAD OF SILENCE OR ATTACK

Under real pressure, most people default to one of two unhelpful patterns: going silent — avoiding the real issue, softening it into vagueness, or disengaging entirely — or going on the attack — getting sharp, sarcastic, or accusatory. Neither actually resolves anything; both just change the shape of the damage.

- ▶ Silence feels safer in the moment but leaves the actual issue unresolved and often festering
- ▶ Attack feels like progress in the moment but usually produces defensiveness rather than real listening
- ▶ The goal is staying in genuine dialogue — saying what actually needs to be said, directly, while still genuinely listening to the other person's view

A CRUCIAL CONVERSATION AVOIDED DOESN'T DISAPPEAR. IT JUST WAITS FOR A WORSE MOMENT TO RESURFACE

PART 4

ADDRESSING A CROSS-DEPARTMENT ISSUE DIRECTLY

WEAK: (*frustrated about a recurring issue, in a hallway, in passing*) "Hey, your team keeps doing this thing that's messing us up — can you guys just fix that?" — vague, public, and delivered without real preparation, which usually produces defensiveness rather than resolution.

STRONG: (*requesting a real conversation, privately*) "Got a few minutes? I want to talk through something that's been happening between our teams — I don't think it's anyone's fault exactly, but I want to understand your side and figure out a fix together, because it's affecting both of us."

The strong version treats the other manager as a partner in solving a shared problem, not an adversary to confront — requested privately, framed around a shared issue rather than blame, and genuinely inviting their perspective before proposing a solution.

- ▶ Request the conversation directly rather than raising it in passing or in front of others
- ▶ Frame the issue as shared, even when your team is the one most visibly affected
- ▶ Come prepared with specifics, but stay genuinely open to hearing something you didn't already know about their side of it

PART 5

KNOWING WHEN TO ESCALATE TO YOUR GM

Not every cross-department issue needs to go to your General Manager — many are best resolved directly between the two managers involved, and escalating routine friction too quickly can actually undermine your own credibility and authority.

- ▶ Try resolving it directly first, using the approach in this module, before involving your GM
- ▶ Escalate when the issue is a genuine pattern that direct conversation hasn't fixed, when it involves a real standard violation, or when you genuinely can't reach a resolution together despite good-faith effort
- ▶ When you do escalate, come with what you've already tried, not just the complaint itself — it shows you've made a real effort and gives your GM something concrete to work with

PART 6

REPAIRING THE RELATIONSHIP AFTERWARD

Even a well-handled crucial conversation can leave some residual tension. What happens in the days after matters as much as the conversation itself for whether the working relationship actually recovers.

- ▶ A short, genuine follow-up — checking that things feel resolved, not just handled — goes a long way toward repairing any lingering tension
- ▶ Look for an early opportunity to collaborate well together after a hard conversation — it rebuilds trust faster than time alone does
- ▶ How you handle the relationship after a hard conversation often matters to a peer manager as much as how you handled the conversation itself

GOAL OF MODULE 21

Every manager can recognize a genuinely crucial conversation, stay in real dialogue rather than defaulting to silence or attack, address cross-department issues directly and privately, know when an issue warrants escalation to their GM, and actively repair the relationship afterward.

MODULE 22 — Change Management

MODULE 21 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what makes cross-department conflict different from conflict within a manager's own team?

- A. A manager has no direct authority over a peer manager's team — only influence and relationship**
- B. Cross-department conflict is always less serious**
- C. Cross-department conflict never involves real stakes**
- D. GMs are required to mediate every cross-department issue**

2. According to Part 2, what three things define a genuinely crucial conversation?

- A. A formal complaint, HR involvement, and documentation**
- B. A scheduled meeting, a written agenda, and two participants**
- C. Low stakes, quick resolution, and no emotional involvement**
- D. High stakes, differing views, and strong emotion**

3. According to Part 3, what are the two unhelpful default patterns people fall into under pressure?

- A. Documentation and escalation**
- B. Silence and attack**
- C. Delegation and deferral**
- D. Compromise and collaboration**

4. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 4, what makes the STRONG version more effective?

- A. It's delivered publicly so both teams can hear the resolution**
- B. It assigns blame clearly to the other manager's team**
- C. It avoids naming the specific issue to keep things comfortable**
- D. It's requested privately, frames the issue as shared, and genuinely invites the other manager's perspective**

5. According to Part 5, when should an issue generally be escalated to the GM?

- A. Never — all cross-department issues must be resolved without GM involvement**
- B. Only if the other manager refuses to speak at all**
- C. Immediately, before attempting to resolve it directly**
- D. Only after a genuine pattern persists despite direct, good-faith conversation, or a real standard violation occurs**

MODULE 22

Change Management

People don't actually resist change. They resist loss — loss of certainty, loss of control, loss of the way things used to make sense. Understand that, and leading a team through change gets a lot more manageable.

Every manager eventually has to lead a team through a change they didn't necessarily choose — a new process, a new tool, a new policy, sometimes a decision that came from well above them. How that change is introduced and led, far more than the change itself, usually determines whether a team adapts quickly or drags their feet for months.

PART 1

WHY CHANGE EFFORTS ACTUALLY FAIL

Change initiatives rarely fail because the change itself was a bad idea. They fail because of how the human beings living through the change experienced it — blindsided, uncertain, or unheard. Recall Module 4's underlying needs: change directly threatens certainty for almost everyone it touches, regardless of whether the change is ultimately good for them.

- ▶ A change announced abruptly, with no warning or context, triggers exactly the uncertainty response Module 4 covers, even when the change itself is reasonable
- ▶ Employees who feel a change was done *to* them resist it far more than employees who feel it was explained, or better yet, done *with* them
- ▶ The technical rollout of a change is usually the easy part. The human adoption of it is where most change efforts actually succeed or fail

PART 2

LEADING CHANGE FROM THE FRONT

A manager who simply announces a change and expects the team to adapt on their own is treating change management as a memo, not as leadership. Leading from the front means being visibly, personally engaged with the change yourself — not just delegating the adjustment to everyone else.

- ▶ Be the first to actually adopt the new process or tool yourself, visibly, rather than expecting the team to figure it out ahead of you
- ▶ Show genuine patience with the early, clumsy period every change goes through — a team watching their manager get frustrated with the awkward transition period learns that frustration is an acceptable response, which makes their own frustration worse
- ▶ Your own state, per Module 5, matters enormously here — a manager who's visibly steady and confident about a change helps the team feel steadier about it too

PART 3

COMMUNICATING THE WHAT, THE WHY, AND THE HOW

Uncertainty is reduced far more by real information than by reassurance alone. A team that understands what's changing, why it's changing, and how it will actually work is far more likely to adapt quickly than a team that's simply told the change is happening.

- ▶ *What.* Be specific about exactly what's changing, not just that "things are changing"

- ▶ *Why.* Explain the actual reasoning, even if it's uncomfortable — "corporate decided" without further explanation reads as dismissive, even when it's technically true
- ▶ *How.* Give the team a concrete sense of what the transition will actually look like day to day, not just the eventual end state

PART 4

ANNOUNCING A CHANGE TO THE TEAM

WEAK: *"Starting Monday, we're doing things differently. I'll explain more as we go."* — leaves the what, the why, and the how all unanswered, which maximizes uncertainty rather than reducing it.

STRONG: *"I want to walk you through a change that's coming Monday. Here's specifically what's changing [specifics], here's why we're making this shift [real reasoning], and here's what the first couple of weeks will actually look like while we all get used to it. I know change is never fully comfortable — I want you to bring me your questions and concerns directly rather than sitting with them."*

The strong version answers the what, the why, and the how in a single conversation, while also explicitly inviting the team's questions rather than treating the announcement as a one-way broadcast.

- ▶ Answer as many of the what/why/how questions as you can before the team even has to ask
- ▶ Explicitly invite questions and concerns, rather than treating silence in the room as agreement
- ▶ Acknowledge directly that change is uncomfortable — pretending otherwise doesn't make the discomfort smaller, it just makes people feel unheard about it

PART 5

HANDLING RESISTANCE WITHOUT DISMISSING IT

Some resistance to change is simply discomfort working itself out, and it usually fades with time and support. Some resistance is pointing at a genuine problem with how the change is being implemented, worth taking seriously rather than brushing aside as mere reluctance.

- ▶ Listen for the specific concern underneath general resistance — often there's a real, fixable issue buried inside what initially sounds like simple complaint
- ▶ Don't dismiss resistance as "just not liking change" without actually checking whether there's a legitimate concern in it
- ▶ A team member who voices resistance directly, respectfully, is often easier to work with long-term than one who goes quiet and simply disengages instead

PART 6

SUSTAINING CHANGE PAST THE INITIAL ANNOUNCEMENT

The announcement is the easiest part of leading change. Sustaining it through the weeks after — when the old habit is still tempting and the new one still feels effortful — is where most change efforts quietly lose momentum.

- ▶ Check in specifically on how the change is going well after the initial announcement, not just in the first few days
- ▶ Recognize and reinforce people who are genuinely adapting well, which helps the change stick faster for everyone watching
- ▶ If real problems with the change surface during rollout, address and adjust them visibly — a team that sees their concerns actually acted on trusts the next change far more than one that watched concerns get raised and ignored

GOAL OF MODULE 22

Every manager understands that people resist the loss of certainty more than the change itself, leads change visibly from the front rather than just announcing it, communicates the what, why, and how clearly, listens for legitimate concerns inside resistance, and sustains the change well past the initial announcement.

MODULE 23 — Apex Manager: A Day in the Life

MODULE 22 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

1. According to Part 1, what does this module say people actually resist about change?
 - A. Only changes that affect their pay directly
 - B. The loss of certainty, control, and the way things used to make sense
 - C. Nothing — most employees embrace any change equally
 - D. The specific new process or tool itself
2. According to Part 2, what does "leading change from the front" mean?
 - A. Being visibly, personally engaged with and among the first to adopt the change
 - B. Delegating the adjustment entirely to the team
 - C. Waiting for the team to adapt before the manager does
 - D. Announcing the change and then stepping back until it's complete
3. According to Part 3, what are the three things a change communication should cover?
 - A. Cost, timeline, and department affected
 - B. What is changing, why it's changing, and how the transition will actually work
 - C. Only the effective date of the change
 - D. Who approved the change, when it was approved, and by whom
4. In the WEAK/STRONG example in Part 4, what does the WEAK version fail to provide?
 - A. A location for the announcement
 - B. An effective date for the change
 - C. Any explanation of what's changing, why, or how the transition will work
 - D. A written summary of the change
5. According to Part 5, what should a manager do when a team member voices resistance to a change?
 - A. Listen for a specific, legitimate concern that might be buried inside the resistance
 - B. Escalate every instance of resistance to the GM
 - C. Automatically treat it as simple reluctance to be managed through
 - D. Dismiss it immediately to maintain momentum

MODULE 23

Apex Manager: A Day in the Life

Not the manager with the best numbers in the building — the manager whose department runs the way it's supposed to whether or not they're standing in it.

Everything in this manual has been covered as a separate skill: coaching, scheduling, reading a dashboard, leading change. In a real day, none of it arrives separately. It all shows up tangled together, often within the same hour, and an Apex Manager is simply someone who's built the habits in this manual deeply enough that the whole day runs as one integrated system instead of a series of disconnected fires.

PART 1

BEFORE THE FIRST TEAM MEMBER ARRIVES

- ▶ **THE STATE RITUAL (MODULE 5)** — Breathe up, posture up, focus up on your North Star, smile and move. Run before the first person walks in, not after the first thing goes wrong.
- ▶ **KNOW WHAT'S COMING (MODULES 9–10)** — A quick look at today's schedule and yesterday's numbers means you're never caught flat-footed by mid-morning. Anticipating the day starts before the doors open, not when the first problem does.

THE APEX STANDARD ISN'T STARTED ON THE FLOOR. IT'S STARTED BEFORE YOU EVER SEE YOUR TEAM

PART 2

LEADING THE FLOOR, START TO FINISH

- ▶ **THE STANDARD YOU CARRY IN (MODULE 3)** — Your team reads your state and your consistency before they read anything you say; the standard you enforce today is the only standard that's actually real.
- ▶ **COACHING AS YOU GO (MODULE 7)** — Small, in-the-moment coaching throughout the day — observe, ask, listen, guide — rather than saving every correction for a formal sit-down.
- ▶ **READING WHAT'S ACTUALLY DRIVING EACH PERSON (MODULE 4)** — The same feedback lands differently depending on what each team member is actually seeking that day — certainty, significance, growth, or something else entirely.

THIS IS THE APEX STANDARD MOST OF YOUR TEAM SEES — BUT IT'S ONLY PART OF THE JOB

PART 3

THE CROSS-DEPARTMENT THREAD

- ▶ **CARRYING PASSPORT ACROSS THE HANDOFF (MODULES 3, 12–15)** — Every handoff out of your department, and every one you receive, is a chance to either keep the customer's journey connected or quietly let it fray.
- ▶ **SPEAKING THE OTHER DEPARTMENTS' LANGUAGE (MODULES 12–15)** — Whether stepping in to cover, answering a customer's question outside your lane, or simply understanding a peer manager's pressures, real fluency across the dealership makes every cross-department moment smoother.
- ▶ **IF YOU'RE MANAGING MANAGERS (MODULES 16–18)** — The same standard scales up: building leaders instead of doing their jobs for them, staying consistent across every department, and carrying the culture personally rather than just repeating it.

WHAT MAKES AN APEX MANAGER DIFFERENT ISN'T DOING ANY ONE OF THESE JOBS WELL — IT'S NEVER LETTING ANY ONE OF THEM SLIP WHILE HANDLING THE OTHERS

PART 4

WHEN SOMETHING GOES WRONG

- ▶ **MANAGING YOUR OWN STATE FIRST (MODULE 5)** — Catching the story before it drives the reaction, especially in the first sixty seconds after bad news lands.
- ▶ **HAVING THE CONVERSATION THAT NEEDS TO HAPPEN (MODULE 8)** — Direct, specific, and structured — situation, behavior, impact, expectation — rather than avoided until it's a bigger problem.
- ▶ **STAYING IN DIALOGUE UNDER REAL PRESSURE (MODULE 21)** — Whether the conflict is inside your own team or with a peer manager, staying in genuine dialogue rather than defaulting to silence or attack.

AN APEX MANAGER ISN'T MEASURED BY HOW OFTEN THINGS GO RIGHT — THEY'RE MEASURED BY HOW THEY HANDLE IT WHEN SOMETHING DOESN'T

PART 5

BUILDING TOWARD TOMORROW

- ▶ Every day is also a small deposit toward a larger goal — the specific result, the real reason, and the next concrete move from Module 19 don't pause just because today got busy
- ▶ A high-performing team, per Module 20, isn't built in a single big moment — it's built in the accumulation of ordinary days handled with real intention
- ▶ Change, when it comes, per Module 22, is led the same way every other hard thing in this manual is led — visibly, honestly, and from the front
- ▶ This manual is a foundation, not a ceiling. Real mastery comes from applying it, day after day, with a real team and real pressure

PART 6

LIVE THE PASSION. LEAD THE RIDE.

- ▶ Every coaching conversation, every fair schedule, every hard conversation handled with respect — it all serves the same purpose: building a team that helps people live a lifestyle they're passionate about
- ▶ You may not personally hand a customer their keys or wrench on their motorcycle, but the team you build determines whether every one of those moments happens the way it's supposed to
- ▶ Sales, Service, Parts, F&I, and every manager above them are all connected into one customer experience — your leadership is the thread that keeps it whole

THE RIDE HAPPENS BECAUSE OF THE TEAM YOU BUILT, LONG BEFORE THE CUSTOMER EVER WALKED IN

GOAL OF MODULE 23

Every manager leaves this manual with a single, unified standard — not a set of separate skills, but one daily system, applied consistently, to every person and every department they lead.

Continue to the Part II Exam.

MODULE 23 REVIEW

Check Your Knowledge

Five questions to confirm you've got this module locked in before moving on.

- 1. According to this module, how should the skills covered across the entire manual be understood?**
 - A. As separate skills to be used only in matching situations**
 - B. As skills relevant only to new managers**
 - C. As one integrated daily system, not a set of disconnected skills**
 - D. As optional techniques to use when convenient**
- 2. What is the first step of the day described in Part 1 of this module?**
 - A. Holding a formal performance review**
 - B. Escalating an issue to the GM**
 - C. Running the State Ritual before the first team member arrives**
 - D. Reviewing yesterday's dashboard numbers**
- 3. According to Part 3, what is true of Apex-level cross-department fluency, whether or not a manager is currently managing other managers?**
 - A. The same underlying standard — building leaders, staying consistent, carrying culture personally — applies and simply scales up**
 - B. Department managers are not expected to understand other departments at all**
 - C. It only applies once a manager reaches the GM level**
 - D. Cross-department fluency is optional for managers with strong department-level numbers**
- 4. According to Part 4, how is an Apex Manager actually measured, according to this module?**
 - A. By how they handle it when something does go wrong**
 - B. By their department's revenue alone**
 - C. By how quickly they escalate every issue**
 - D. By how rarely anything goes wrong**
- 5. According to this module, what is this manual meant to be?**
 - A. A ceiling — the full extent of what's needed to lead well**
 - B. A one-time certification requiring no further practice**
 - C. A reference used only during a manager's first week**
 - D. A foundation, with real mastery coming from ongoing, day-after-day application**

PART II EXAM

Advanced Leadership & the General Manager

20 questions covering everything in Part II. Circle your answers, then check the key at the end.

1. According to Module 15, why does F&I Academy train F&I Managers, Sales Professionals, and Service Advisors together in one manual?

- A. Sales Professionals process all F&I paperwork themselves
- B. State law requires all three roles to receive identical training
- C. Only F&I Managers actually need this training
- D. All three roles touch this part of the customer journey and need to understand it

2. According to Module 15, what should happen when a customer declines a protection product?

- A. A manager should attempt the sale personally
- B. The sale should be paused indefinitely
- C. The decision should be respected, not treated as a failure to close
- D. A second, harder pitch should follow

3. According to Module 16, what is a General Manager's real job, as this module defines it?

- A. Serving as a backup employee for any short-staffed department
- B. Personally running each department directly
- C. Making sure each department manager leads well and the dealership functions as one team
- D. Handling only dealership-wide financial reporting

4. According to Module 16, what should a GM generally do when a department manager makes a defensible decision the GM would have made differently?

- A. Quietly reverse the decision without discussion
- B. Escalate the decision to corporate
- C. Override the decision immediately
- D. Let the decision stand, since disagreement on approach isn't the same as the decision being wrong

5. According to Module 17, what is a common friction point between Sales and F&I?

- A. F&I has no real interaction with the Sales process
- B. Sales' pace and volume can pressure F&I to move faster than a thorough conversation allows
- C. F&I sets the final price on every motorcycle sold
- D. Sales and F&I never work on the same deal

6. According to Module 17, what is a GM's specific responsibility regarding Passport, beyond what an individual department manager owns?

- A. Personally performing every customer handoff
- B. Auditing Passport only once per year
- C. Making sure the Passport thread holds together across all four departments
- D. None — Passport is entirely department-level

7. According to Module 18, what determines a dealership's real culture, according to this module?

- A. What leadership actually rewards, ignores, and corrects — not what leadership says**
- B. The dealership's annual revenue**
- C. The written employee handbook**
- D. How long the dealership has been in business**

8. According to Module 18, what does this module say about a culture that only holds up when the GM is present?

- A. It only matters if it affects revenue**
- B. It isn't a real culture — it's compliance, and it collapses once attention shifts elsewhere**
- C. It indicates the GM should be present at all times as a permanent fix**
- D. That's the expected and desired outcome**

9. According to Module 19, what does this module recommend starting the planning process with?

- A. A detailed task list, with the result attached loosely at the end**
- B. A specific, clearly defined result, working backward to the tasks that produce it**
- C. A budget analysis**
- D. A review of the team's current schedule**

10. According to Module 19, what tends to sustain motivation toward a goal longer than the number itself?

- A. Keeping the goal private until it's achieved**
- B. Frequent reminders about the deadline**
- C. A larger financial incentive in every case**
- D. A genuine reason connected to something the team actually cares about**

11. According to Module 20, what does this module say is the real differentiator between a good team and a high-performing one?

- A. The environment the manager has deliberately built**
- B. The individual talent level of the team members**
- C. The size of the team**
- D. The department's overall budget**

12. According to Module 20, what does a "suspiciously conflict-free" team often actually signal?

- A. Genuine harmony and strong alignment**
- B. That people have learned speaking up isn't safe**
- C. A well-designed incentive structure**
- D. Strong peer accountability**

13. According to Module 21, what makes cross-department conflict different from conflict within a manager's own team?

- A. Cross-department conflict never involves real stakes**
- B. GMs are required to mediate every cross-department issue**
- C. A manager has no direct authority over a peer manager's team — only influence and relationship**
- D. Cross-department conflict is always less serious**

14. According to Module 21, what three things define a genuinely crucial conversation?
- A. A scheduled meeting, a written agenda, and two participants
 - B. Low stakes, quick resolution, and no emotional involvement
 - C. A formal complaint, HR involvement, and documentation
 - D. High stakes, differing views, and strong emotion
15. According to Module 22, what does this module say people actually resist about change?
- A. Nothing — most employees embrace any change equally
 - B. The specific new process or tool itself
 - C. Only changes that affect their pay directly
 - D. The loss of certainty, control, and the way things used to make sense
16. According to Module 22, what are the three things a change communication should cover?
- A. Only the effective date of the change
 - B. Cost, timeline, and department affected
 - C. Who approved the change, when, and by whom
 - D. What is changing, why it's changing, and how the transition will actually work
17. According to Module 23, how should the skills covered across this entire manual be understood?
- A. As optional techniques to use when convenient
 - B. As skills relevant only to new managers
 - C. As one integrated daily system, not a set of disconnected skills
 - D. As separate skills to be used only in matching situations
18. According to Module 23, how is an Apex Manager actually measured?
- A. By how rarely anything ever goes wrong
 - B. By how quickly they escalate every issue
 - C. By their department's revenue alone
 - D. By how they handle it when something does go wrong
19. According to Module 16, why is coaching a department manager described as a "force multiplier"?
- A. It only benefits the manager being coached
 - B. It pays off every day that manager runs their department, multiplying the GM's impact
 - C. It replaces the need for department-level coaching entirely
 - D. It reduces the GM's workload with no other benefit
20. According to Module 23, what is this manual meant to be?
- A. A one-time certification requiring no further practice
 - B. A reference used only during a manager's first week
 - C. A foundation, with real mastery coming from ongoing, day-after-day application
 - D. A ceiling — the full extent of what's needed

ANSWER KEY

All Module Reviews & Part Exams

MODULE 01 REVIEW

1. C 2. A 3. D 4. A 5. D

MODULE 02 REVIEW

1. B 2. C 3. C 4. D 5. D

MODULE 03 REVIEW

1. D 2. D 3. B 4. C 5. A

MODULE 04 REVIEW

1. D 2. D 3. C 4. B 5. B

MODULE 05 REVIEW

1. C 2. A 3. C 4. C 5. B

MODULE 06 REVIEW

1. A 2. A 3. D 4. D 5. A

MODULE 07 REVIEW

1. B 2. C 3. B 4. C 5. D

MODULE 08 REVIEW

1. D 2. D 3. C 4. B 5. D

MODULE 09 REVIEW

1. A 2. B 3. D 4. B 5. D

MODULE 10 REVIEW

1. B 2. B 3. D 4. A 5. B

MODULE 11 REVIEW

1. B 2. D 3. D 4. C 5. D

MODULE 12 REVIEW

1. A 2. C 3. B 4. D 5. D

MODULE 13 REVIEW

1. A 2. A 3. A 4. B 5. D

MODULE 14 REVIEW

1. D 2. C 3. A 4. D 5. B

PART I EXAM

1. A 2. D 3. C 4. B 5. D 6. C 7. C 8. B 9. B 10. B 11. A 12. A 13. A 14. C 15. D 16. B
17. D 18. C 19. B 20. C

MODULE 15 REVIEW

1. C 2. A 3. B 4. A 5. B

MODULE 16 REVIEW

1. D 2. D 3. A 4. B 5. B

MODULE 17 REVIEW

1. D 2. C 3. A 4. D 5. D

MODULE 18 REVIEW

1. A 2. B 3. C 4. A 5. A

MODULE 19 REVIEW

1. A 2. D 3. B 4. B 5. A

MODULE 20 REVIEW

1. D 2. B 3. B 4. D 5. A

MODULE 21 REVIEW

1. A 2. D 3. B 4. D 5. D

MODULE 22 REVIEW

1. B 2. A 3. B 4. C 5. A

MODULE 23 REVIEW

1. C 2. C 3. A 4. A 5. D

PART II EXAM

1. D 2. C 3. C 4. D 5. B 6. C 7. A 8. B 9. B 10. D 11. A 12. B 13. C 14. D 15. D 16. D
17. C 18. D 19. B 20. C